NESTED SWEEPOUTS AND FREE BOUNDARY MIN-MAX THEORY IN COMPLETE RIEMANNIAN MANIFOLDS

BY

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ABSTRACT

Nested Sweepouts and Free Boundary Min-Max Theory in Complete Riemannian Manifolds
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We extend the min–max theory for free-boundary minimal hypersurfaces to complete Riemannian manifolds with boundary and sublinear volume growth.

To my parents,
for their unconditional support.

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1

PART 1: FREE BOUNDARY MIN-MAX THEORY IN COMPLETE RIEMANNIAN MANIFOLDS

1.1 INTRODUCTION

The existence of minimal hypersurfaces is a central problem in differential geometry and the calculus of variations. The Almgren–Pitts min-max theory [Alm65, Pit81], together with the regularity results of Schoen–Simon [SS81], establishes that every closed Riemannian manifold M^{n+1} with $2 \leq n \leq 6$ contains a smooth, closed, embedded minimal hypersurface. This foundational result has since inspired far-reaching developments, including the resolution of the Willmore conjecture by Marques–Neves [MN14], Yau's conjecture on infinitely many minimal hypersurfaces by Marques–Neves [MN17] (for positive Ricci curvature) and Song [Son23] (in full generality), and the generic equidistribution results of Irie–Marques–Neves [IMN18] and Marques–Neves–Song [MNS19].

Two natural directions of generalization arise. The first concerns manifolds *with boundary*: given a compact Riemannian manifold M with nonempty boundary ∂M, one seeks *free boundary minimal hypersurfaces* — hypersurfaces that are minimal in the interior and meet ∂M orthogonally along their boundary. Li–Zhou [LZ21] developed a min-max theory for free boundary minimal hypersurfaces and proved that every smooth com-

pact Riemannian manifold M^{n+1} ($2 \leq n \leq 6$) with $\partial M \neq \varnothing$ contains such a hypersurface, without any assumption on the geometry or topology of M or ∂M.

The second direction concerns *non-compact* manifolds. For complete non-compact manifolds without boundary, Chambers–Liokumovich [CL20] introduced a localized min-max framework based on *good sets*: bounded open sets $U \subset M$ whose interior boundary $\partial_I U$ is small relative to the width $W(U)$. The intuition is as follows (see Figure 1.1): on a manifold of finite volume (or, more generally, of sublinear volume growth), one can find a bounded open set U whose interior boundary $\partial_I U$ is located at a narrow neck, so that $\mathbf{M}(\partial_I U)$ is small compared to the width $W(U)$. This smallness is crucial for the min-max construction: the initial and terminal slices of the sweepout can be chosen to have mass bounded by $\mathbf{M}(\partial_I U)$, so the min-max value — the width $W(U)$ — is strictly larger than the mass of the boundary slices, guaranteeing that the min-max procedure produces a non-trivial minimal hypersurface. Using good sets, Chambers–Liokumovich proved that every complete non-compact manifold of finite volume (more generally, of sublinear volume growth) contains a closed embedded minimal hypersurface.

This thesis combines both directions: we develop a min-max theory for free boundary minimal hypersurfaces on *complete, non-compact* Riemannian manifolds *with boundary*. Our main result is the following.

Theorem 1.1.1 (Main Theorem)**.** *Let (M^{n+1}, g) be a complete Riemannian manifold with non-empty smooth boundary ∂M, $2 \leq n \leq 6$. Let $U \subset M$ be a* good set *(Definition 1.2.20), i.e., a bounded open set of finite perimeter satisfying $\mathbf{M}(\partial_I U) \leq \frac{1}{10} W_\partial(U)$, with $\overline{U} \cap \partial M \neq \varnothing$. Then there exists a smooth, almost properly embedded minimal hypersurface $(\Sigma, \partial\Sigma) \subset (M, \partial M)$ with (possibly empty) boundary $\partial\Sigma \subset \partial M$ such that*

(i) *Σ is minimal in the interior and meets ∂M orthogonally along $\partial\Sigma$;*

(ii) (Area bound) $\mathcal{H}^n(\Sigma) \leq W_\partial(U) + \mathbf{M}(\partial_I U)$;

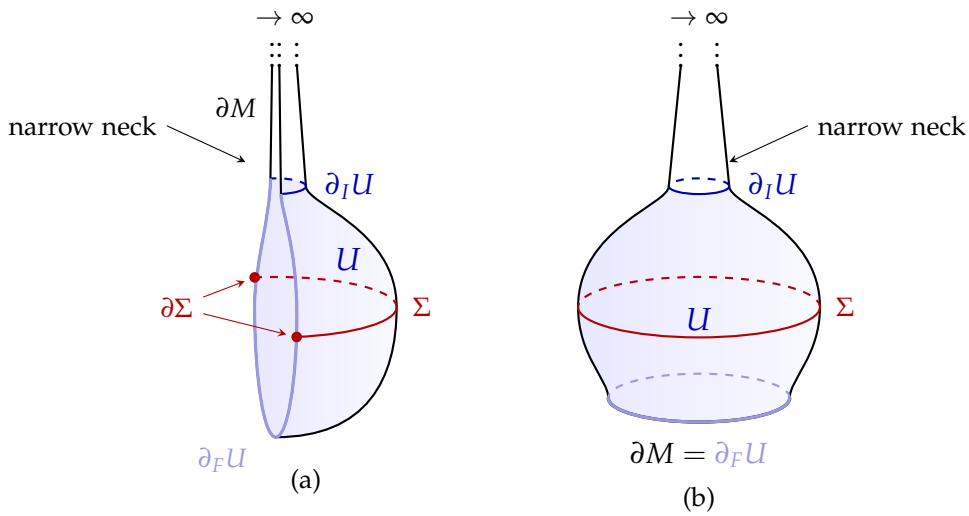

Figure 1.1: A good set U (shaded) inside a non-compact manifold M with boundary ∂M. The *interior boundary* $\partial_I U$ sits at a narrow neck, so $\mathbf{M}(\partial_I U)$ is small relative to $W_\partial(U)$; the *free boundary* $\partial_F U = \overline{U} \cap \partial M$ is shown in light blue. The min-max hypersurface Σ (red) produced by Theorem 1.1.1 may or may not have boundary, depending on the geometry of ∂M: (a) ∂M runs parallel to the neck, and Σ is a *free boundary* minimal hypersurface with $\partial\Sigma \neq \varnothing$ meeting ∂M orthogonally (red dots); (b) ∂M is transverse to the neck, and Σ is a *closed* minimal hypersurface ($\partial\Sigma = \varnothing$) contained in the interior of M.

(iii) (Localization) $\Sigma \cap \overline{U} \neq \varnothing$.

We now explain the conclusions of the theorem. First, Σ is asserted to be *almost properly embedded* in M, a notion introduced by Li–Zhou [LZ21]. This means that $\Sigma \subset M$ and $\partial\Sigma \subset \partial M$, but Σ may additionally touch ∂M tangentially at interior points of Σ. Such points are called *false boundary points*: at a false boundary point $p \in (\Sigma \setminus \partial\Sigma) \cap \partial M$, the tangent plane of Σ coincides with that of ∂M, and Σ touches ∂M from the interior of M (see [LZ21, Figure 1] for an illustration). The stronger condition that $\Sigma \cap \partial M = \partial\Sigma$ (no false boundary points) is called *proper embedding*. This subtlety does not arise in the boundaryless case of Chambers–Liokumovich [CL20], where the min-max hypersurface is embedded in the usual sense. In the presence

of ∂M, however, the regularity theory ([LZ21, Theorem 6.2]; see Section 1.7) relies on a compactness theorem for stable free boundary minimal hypersurfaces ([LZ21, Theorem 2.13]), which only preserves almost proper embedding: a sequence of properly embedded hypersurfaces may converge to a limit that is merely almost properly embedded, acquiring false boundary points in the limit (see [LZ21, Figure 2]). We note that this issue is confined to the regularity theory: the sweepout construction, nested sweepout machinery, and no-escape-to-infinity argument (Sections 1.3–1.6) operate entirely at the level of currents and do not involve smooth hypersurfaces, so false boundary points play no role there.

Turning to the three numbered conclusions: (i) is the defining property of a free boundary minimal hypersurface, as introduced in [LZ21]. In (ii), $W_\partial(U)$ denotes the *relative width* of U (Definition 1.2.18), which is the width computed from sweepouts whose slices are restricted to $\overline{U}$; it measures the intrinsic "waist" of U (see Remark 1.1.2 for why this is the appropriate notion of width).

Conclusions (ii) and (iii) together address issues specific to the non-compact setting. The localization condition $\Sigma \cap \overline{U} \neq \varnothing$ ensures that the limit hypersurface does not escape to infinity: it genuinely passes through the good set U. However, localization alone does not prevent the hypersurface from extending far beyond U with most of its area at infinity; the area bound provides the complementary control. Combined with the good set condition $\mathbf{M}(\partial_I U) \leq \frac{1}{10} W_\partial(U)$ (Definition 1.2.20), it yields $\mathcal{H}^n(\Sigma) \leq \frac{11}{10} W_\partial(U)$, so the area of Σ is controlled at the scale of the width of U, giving a geometrically meaningful minimal hypersurface that lives at the scale of the good set (see Figure 1.1). In the compact setting both conclusions are automatic, but on non-compact manifolds they require the good set machinery of Chambers–Liokumovich [CL20] together with the no-escape-to-infinity argument developed in Section 1.6.

Remark 1.1.2 (Why the relative width). Several notions of width appear in the min-max framework: the (unrestricted) width $W(U)$, the *relative width*

$W_\partial(U)$ (Definition 1.2.18), and the *good width* $W_g(U)$ (Definition 1.2.16). In the boundaryless case, Chambers–Liokumovich [CL20] establish

$$W_\partial(U) \;\le\; W(U) = W_g(U) \;\le\; W_\partial(U) + \mathbf{M}(\partial U),$$

where ∂U is the full boundary of U inside M. In our setting, where M has boundary ∂M, the boundary of U splits as $\partial U = \partial_I U \cup \partial_F U$, and only the interior boundary $\partial_I U$ contributes to the gap; we prove (Proposition 1.2.19) that the same inequalities hold with $\mathbf{M}(\partial U)$ replaced by $\mathbf{M}(\partial_I U)$:

$$W_\partial(U) \;\le\; W(U) = W_g(U) \;\le\; W_\partial(U) + \mathbf{M}(\partial_I U).$$

Here $W(U) = W_g(U)$ is a non-trivial theorem (Proposition 1.2.19(iii)). The gap $W(U) - W_\partial(U) \le \mathbf{M}(\partial_I U)$ arises because slices of an unrestricted sweepout may spill over $\partial_I U$, contributing extra area up to $\mathbf{M}(\partial_I U)$ that is irrelevant to the geometry of U itself. The good width $W_g(U)$ plays a key role in the *proof* — the pulled-tight process requires good sweepouts whose initial and terminal slices have small mass — but in the *statement* of the theorem, the relative width $W_\partial(U)$ gives the sharpest area bound.

Organization of the thesis. Section 1.2 collects the analytical foundations: integer rectifiable currents, relative cycles, varifolds, and the sweepout framework needed for the min-max construction on manifolds with boundary.

The core of the proof occupies Sections 1.3–1.7. Section 1.3 develops Morse foliations with controlled fiber area, the building blocks for converting arbitrary sweepouts into nested ones. Section 1.4 establishes the splitting and extension lemmas that allow local nested families to be glued together with controlled mass increase. These tools are combined in Section 1.5, which constructs nested sweepouts from arbitrary sweepouts — the key technical input for the no-escape argument. Section 1.6 proves that any good sweepout must carry definite mass inside the good set U, preventing the min-max sequence from escaping to infinity. Finally, Section 1.7

completes the proof: a pull-tight procedure adapted to the non-compact setting via exhaustion produces a stationary varifold, which is shown to be almost minimizing in small annuli with free boundary; the regularity theory of Li–Zhou [LZ21] then yields the smooth, almost properly embedded free boundary minimal hypersurface of Theorem 1.1.1.

1.2 SETTINGS AND PRELIMINARIES

This section establishes the foundational framework for the free boundary min-max theory in complete Riemannian manifolds with boundary.

Let (M^{n+1}, g) be a smooth, complete Riemannian manifold with non-empty smooth boundary ∂M. We assume $2 \leq n \leq 6$ throughout. We write $\nu_{\partial M}$ for the inward unit normal to ∂M. For details on Fermi coordinates near ∂M, see [LZ21, Section 2].

We denote by $\mathcal{H}^k$ the k-dimensional Hausdorff measure and by $\mathbf{M}(T)$ the mass of a current T. We assume M is isometrically embedded in some $\mathbb{R}^L$. For vector fields, let $\mathfrak{X}_c(M)$ denote the space of *compactly supported* smooth vector fields on M that are tangent to M:

$$\mathfrak{X}_c(M) := \big\{X \in \mathfrak{X}(\mathbb{R}^L) : X \text{ is compactly supported}, \\ X(p) \in T_pM \text{ for all } p \in M\big\}.$$

The subspace of vector fields additionally tangent to the boundary is

$$\mathfrak{X}_{\tan}(M) := \{X \in \mathfrak{X}_c(M) : X(p) \in T_p(\partial M) \text{ for all } p \in \partial M\}.$$

Remark 1.2.1 (Role of the isometric embedding). The assumption that M is isometrically embedded in $\mathbb{R}^L$ (which exists by Nash's embedding theorem [Nas56]) is needed because integer rectifiable currents are defined as functionals on differential forms in an ambient Euclidean space (see Simon [Sim84, §26–27], Li–Zhou [LZ21, §3]).

For a relatively open subset $U \subset M$, we write $\mathrm{int}_M(U)$ for the relative interior of U in M. We use $A \Subset B$ to denote that $\overline{A}$ is compact and contained in B.

Currents and Varifolds

We work with currents and relative cycles following Li–Zhou [LZ21]. We write $\mathcal{R}_k(M;\mathbb{Z}_2)$ for the space of mod 2 flat chains supported in M, with mass norm $\mathbf{M}$ and flat topology.

Remark 1.2.2 (Coefficient group). Throughout this thesis we work with $\mathbb{Z}_2$ coefficients. The reduced boundary $\partial^*\Omega$ of a Caccioppoli set carries no canonical orientation, only a distinction between interior and exterior, so $\mathbb{Z}_2$ is the natural coefficient group. Li–Zhou [LZ21] state their results for $\mathbb{Z}$ coefficients, but the key tools—the isoperimetric lemma, slicing theorem, and regularity theory—hold equally for $\mathbb{Z}_2$ (see [MN17, Alm62]).

Definition 1.2.3 (Relative cycles and equivalence classes)**.** For subsets $A \supset B$ of M, the space of *relative cycles* is

$$\mathcal{Z}_n(A,B;\mathbb{Z}_2) := \{T \in \mathcal{R}_n(M;\mathbb{Z}_2) : \mathrm{spt}(T) \subset A,\ \mathrm{spt}(\partial T) \subset B\},$$

equipped with the flat topology. The *space of equivalence classes of relative cycles* is the quotient

$$\mathbf{Z}_n(A,B;\mathbb{Z}_2) := \mathcal{Z}_n(A,B;\mathbb{Z}_2)/\mathcal{Z}_n(B,B;\mathbb{Z}_2).$$

Two cycles $T_1, T_2 \in \mathcal{Z}_n(A,B;\mathbb{Z}_2)$ represent the same class $\tau \in \mathbf{Z}_n(A,B;\mathbb{Z}_2)$ if and only if $T_1 - T_2 \in \mathcal{Z}_n(B,B;\mathbb{Z}_2)$, i.e., $T_1 - T_2$ is supported in B.

Proposition 1.2.4 (Caccioppoli sets and mod 2 cycles)**.** *Let $\Omega \subset M$ be a measurable subset. Then Ω is a Caccioppoli set (i.e.* $\mathrm{Per}(\Omega) < \infty$*) if and only*

if the integration current $[\![\Omega]\!] \in \mathcal{R}_{n+1}(M;\mathbb{Z}_2)$ *satisfies* $\mathbf{M}(\partial[\![\Omega]\!]) < \infty$. *In this case,*

$$\partial[\![\Omega]\!] \in \mathcal{Z}_n(M, \partial M; \mathbb{Z}_2)$$

is a mod 2 *relative cycle with*

$$\mathrm{Per}(\Omega) = \mathbf{M}(\partial[\![\Omega]\!]).$$

The current $\partial[\![\Omega]\!]$ *is supported on the reduced boundary:* $\partial^*\Omega \subset \mathbf{spt}\partial[\![\Omega]\!] \subset \overline{\partial^*\Omega}$, *and the varifold* $|\partial^*\Omega|$ *induced by the reduced boundary agrees with the varifold* $|\partial[\![\Omega]\!]|$ *induced by the mod* 2 *current. Moreover,* Ω *and* $M \setminus \Omega$ *induce the same mod* 2 *cycle:* $\partial[\![\Omega]\!] = \partial[\![M \setminus \Omega]\!]$.

Proof. The set Ω defines an integer rectifiable $(n+1)$-current $[\![\Omega]\!]$ by integration: $[\![\Omega]\!](\omega) = \int_\Omega \omega$ for any smooth $(n+1)$-form ω. Reducing modulo 2, we regard $[\![\Omega]\!] \in \mathcal{R}_{n+1}(M;\mathbb{Z}_2)$. By definition, Ω is a Caccioppoli set if and only if its distributional boundary μ_Ω is a finite Radon measure, i.e. $|\mu_\Omega|(M) < \infty$. Since both $|\mu_\Omega|(M)$ and $\mathbf{M}(\partial[\![\Omega]\!])$ express the total variation of the distributional derivative of $\mathbf{1}_\Omega$, we have $|\mu_\Omega|(M) = \mathbf{M}(\partial[\![\Omega]\!])$, and the equivalence $\mathrm{Per}(\Omega) < \infty \Leftrightarrow \mathbf{M}(\partial[\![\Omega]\!]) < \infty$ follows.

The chain complex axiom gives $\partial(\partial[\![\Omega]\!]) = \partial^2[\![\Omega]\!] = 0$, so $\mathrm{spt}(\partial(\partial[\![\Omega]\!])) = \emptyset \subset \partial M$ and $\partial[\![\Omega]\!] \in \mathcal{Z}_n(M, \partial M; \mathbb{Z}_2)$.

By De Giorgi's structure theorem (Maggi [Mag12, Theorem 15.9]), the Gauss–Green measure satisfies $|\mu_\Omega| = \mathcal{H}^n \llcorner \partial^*\Omega$, and the density $\Theta^n(\partial^*\Omega, x) = 1$ for every $x \in \partial^*\Omega$ (Maggi [Mag12, Corollary 15.8]). Therefore

$$\mathbf{M}(\partial[\![\Omega]\!]) = |\mu_\Omega|(M) = \mathcal{H}^n(\partial^*\Omega) = \mathrm{Per}(\Omega),$$

and $\partial^*\Omega \subset \mathbf{spt}\partial[\![\Omega]\!] \subset \overline{\partial^*\Omega}$. Note that the current $\partial[\![\Omega]\!]$ is defined by first forming the integration current and then applying ∂, requiring no a priori knowledge of the reduced boundary. One could alternatively define an n-current $[\![\partial^*\Omega]\!]$ by integrating directly over $\partial^*\Omega$; De Giorgi's structure theorem identifies the two: $\partial[\![\Omega]\!] = [\![\partial^*\Omega]\!]$. Throughout this thesis we

write $[\![\partial\Omega]\!] := \partial[\![\Omega]\!]$, with the understanding that $\partial\Omega$ refers to the reduced boundary $\partial^*\Omega$ in the context of currents.

Since $\partial[\![\Omega]\!]$ is carried by $\partial^*\Omega$ with multiplicity one, the associated varifold $|\partial[\![\Omega]\!]|$ acts on $f \in C_c(G_n(M))$ by

$$|\partial[\![\Omega]\!]|\,(f) = \int_{\partial^*\Omega} f(x, T_x(\partial^*\Omega))\, d\mathcal{H}^n(x) = |\partial^*\Omega|\,(f),$$

where $T_x(\partial^*\Omega)$ is the approximate tangent plane, which exists $\mathcal{H}^n$-a.e. by rectifiability.

Finally, in $\mathbb{Z}_2$ coefficients we have $[\![\Omega]\!] + [\![M \setminus \Omega]\!] = [\![M]\!]$. Since $\partial[\![M]\!]$ is supported on ∂M, it vanishes as a relative cycle in $\mathcal{Z}_n(M, \partial M; \mathbb{Z}_2)$, so $\partial[\![\Omega]\!] + \partial[\![M \setminus \Omega]\!] = 0$, which in $\mathbb{Z}_2$ gives $\partial[\![\Omega]\!] = \partial[\![M \setminus \Omega]\!]$. □

The min-max machinery of Li–Zhou [LZ21] operates on equivalence classes of relative cycles rather than on individual currents. We therefore need a well-defined notion of mass on these classes.

Definition 1.2.5 (Canonical representative)**.** For $\tau \in \mathbf{Z}_n(A, B; \mathbb{Z}_2)$, there exists a unique representative $T \in \tau$ satisfying $T \llcorner B = 0$. This T is called the *canonical representative* of τ. When no confusion arises, we identify τ with its canonical representative.

Definition 1.2.6 (Mass of an equivalence class)**.** For $\tau \in \mathbf{Z}_n(A, B; \mathbb{Z}_2)$, the *mass* of τ is defined as $\mathbf{M}(\tau) := \mathbf{M}(T)$, where T is the canonical representative of τ. By [LZ21, Lemma 3.3], $\mathbf{M}(\tau) = \inf_{S \in \tau} \mathbf{M}(S)$, so the canonical representative achieves the infimum of mass over all representatives.

Given a Caccioppoli set Ω, we refer to the $(n+1)$-current $[\![\Omega]\!]$ as the *filling* of the relative cycle $\partial[\![\Omega]\!]$. For $\tau \in \mathbf{Z}_n(M, \partial M; \mathbb{Z}_2)$ with canonical representative T, the mass restricted to an open set V is $\|\tau\|(V) := \mathbf{M}(T \llcorner V)$.

Definition 1.2.7 (Interior boundary and free boundary part)**.** For a measurable set $\Omega \subset M$ with $\mathbf{M}(\partial[\![\Omega]\!]) < \infty$, the boundary current decomposes as

$$\partial[\![\Omega]\!] = \partial_I\Omega + \partial_F\Omega,$$

where:

- $\partial_I \Omega := \partial[\![\Omega]\!] \llcorner \mathrm{int}(M)$ is the *interior boundary*, supported on $\overline{\partial^* \Omega} \cap \mathrm{int}(M)$;
- $\partial_F \Omega := \partial[\![\Omega]\!] \llcorner \partial M$ is the *free boundary part*, supported on $\overline{\partial^* \Omega} \cap \partial M$.

In Sections 1.5 and 1.6, we localise a global sweepout to a good set $U \subset M$ in order to apply the min-max theory on a precompact domain. This localisation requires cutting the Caccioppoli sets Ω_t along the interior boundary $\partial_I U$, which may introduce extra area near $\partial_I U$. To control this, we use the coarea inequality to find cut-off radii where the extra area is small. Throughout we use the following standard fact:

Lemma 1.2.8 (Coarea inequality)**.** *Let $\Omega \subset M$ be a bounded open set of finite perimeter and $f \colon M \to \mathbb{R}$ a Lipschitz function. Then for almost every $t \in \mathbb{R}$, the level set $f^{-1}(t) \cap \Omega$ has finite $\mathcal{H}^n$-measure, and*

$$\int_{\mathbb{R}} \mathcal{H}^n(f^{-1}(t) \cap \Omega)\, dt \leq \int_{\Omega} |\nabla f|\, d\mathcal{H}^{n+1}.$$

The min-max procedure produces limit objects not as currents but as varifolds: the pull-tight argument of Section 1.7 yields a stationary varifold, and the regularity theory ([LZ21, Theorem 6.2]; see also Chapter 2) recovers a smooth minimal hypersurface from it. We recall the basic definitions; standard references include Pitts [Pit81], Simon [Sim84], Colding–De Lellis [CL03], and De Lellis–Tasnady [DLT13].

Definition 1.2.9 (Varifolds)**.** Let $\mathrm{Gr}_n(M)$ denote the Grassmannian bundle of (unoriented) n-planes over M. An *n-varifold* on M is a Radon measure on $\mathrm{Gr}_n(M)$. The space of all n-varifolds is denoted $\mathcal{V}_n(M)$, equipped with the weak-$*$ topology.

For $V \in \mathcal{V}_n(M)$, the *mass measure* $\|V\|$ is the pushforward of V under the projection $\mathrm{Gr}_n(M) \to M$. The *total mass* is $\|V\|(M)$, and the *support* is $\mathrm{spt}\,\|V\|$. For an open set $A \subset M$, the *restriction* $V \llcorner A$ is the varifold defined by $V \llcorner A(E) := V(E \cap \mathrm{Gr}_n(A))$.

Definition 1.2.10 (First variation)**.** The *first variation* of $V \in \mathcal{V}_n(M)$ is the linear functional on smooth vector fields defined by

$$\delta V(X) := \int_{\mathrm{Gr}_n(M)} \mathrm{div}_S\, X(x)\, dV(x,S),$$

where $\mathrm{div}_S\, X(x) := \sum_{i=1}^n \langle \nabla_{e_i} X, e_i \rangle$ for any orthonormal basis $\{e_i\}$ of S.

Definition 1.2.11 (Stationarity)**.** A varifold $V \in \mathcal{V}_n(M)$ is:

(i) *stationary in* $\mathrm{int}(M)$ if $\delta V(X) = 0$ for all $X \in \mathfrak{X}_c(\mathrm{int}(M))$;

(ii) *stationary with free boundary* if $\delta V(X) = 0$ for all $X \in \mathfrak{X}_{\tan}(M)$.

The pull-tight procedure (Section 1.7) requires a metric on the space of varifolds that metrises weak-$*$ convergence and behaves well under localisation to open subsets. This role is played by the **F**-metric.

Definition 1.2.12 (**F**-metric)**.** The **F**-*metric* on $\mathcal{V}_n(M)$ is defined by

$$\mathbf{F}(V,W) := \sup\left\{ \int f\, dV - \int f\, dW : f \in C_c(\mathrm{Gr}_n(M)),\ |f| \le 1,\ \mathrm{Lip}(f) \le 1 \right\}.$$

On sets of uniformly bounded mass, **F** metrizes the weak-$*$ topology. For an open set $U \subset M$, the *localized* **F**-*metric* is $\mathbf{F}_U(V,W) := \mathbf{F}(V \llcorner U, W \llcorner U)$. See [LZ21, Section 2].

Sweepouts, Width, and Good Sets

The cut-and-paste operations in our proof (splitting, extension, and nested sweepout construction in Sections 1.4–1.6) are most naturally described using Caccioppoli sets. We therefore adopt a continuous sweepout framework based on Caccioppoli sets (sets of finite perimeter), following the approach of Chambers–Liokumovich [CL20] and De Lellis–Tasnady [DLT13]. In Proposition 1.2.15 below, we show that every Caccioppoli sweepout gives rise to a continuous map into the space of mod 2 relative cycles; this is the

bridge that allows us to invoke the min-max machinery of Li–Zhou [LZ21] (pull-tight, almost minimizing, regularity) developed in the cycle-valued setting. For applications to non-compact manifolds, we consider sweepouts of bounded open sets.

Definition 1.2.13 (Sweepout of $(U, \partial_F U)$)**.** Let $U \subset M$ be a bounded relatively open set of finite perimeter. A *sweepout of* $(U, \partial_F U)$ is a family of Caccioppoli sets $\{\Omega_t\}_{t\in[0,1]}$ in M satisfying:

(sw1) **Boundary condition**: $\Omega_0 \cap U = \emptyset$ and $U \subset \Omega_1$;

(sw2) **Continuity**: the map $t \mapsto \mathbf{1}_{\Omega_t}$ is continuous in $L^1(M)$, i.e.,

$$\mathcal{H}^{n+1}(\Omega_t \triangle \Omega_s) \to 0 \quad \text{as } s \to t;$$

(sw3) **Finite mass**: $\sup_{t\in[0,1]} \mathrm{Per}(\Omega_t) < \infty$;

(sw4) **No mass concentration**: for every $x \in M$,

$$\lim_{r\to 0} \sup_{t\in[0,1]} \mathrm{Per}(\Omega_t, B_r(x)) = 0.$$

The *height* of the sweepout is $F(\{\Omega_t\}) := \sup_{t\in[0,1]} \mathrm{Per}(\Omega_t)$.

Definition 1.2.14 (Width)**.** The *width* of $(U, \partial_F U)$ is

$$W(U) := \inf\big\{F(\{\Omega_t\}) : \{\Omega_t\} \text{ is a sweepout of } (U, \partial_F U)\big\}.$$

The following proposition provides the bridge between the Caccioppoli sweepout framework and the cycle-valued maps used in Li–Zhou [LZ21].

Proposition 1.2.15 (From Caccioppoli sweepouts to cycle-valued maps)**.** *Let $\{\Omega_t\}_{t\in[0,1]}$ be a sweepout of $(U, \partial_F U)$. Then the map*

$$\Phi : [0,1] \to \mathcal{Z}_n(M, \partial M; \mathbb{Z}_2), \quad t \mapsto \partial[\![\Omega_t]\!]$$

is continuous in the flat topology $\mathcal{F}$, and satisfies $\mathbf{M}(\Phi(t)) = \mathrm{Per}(\Omega_t)$ for all t by Proposition 1.2.4. Moreover, Φ satisfies the no mass concentration condition

$$\lim_{r\to 0} \sup_{t\in[0,1]} \|\Phi(t)\|(B_r(x)) = 0 \quad \textit{for every } x \in M.$$

Proof. The mass identity and no concentration condition are immediate from Proposition 1.2.4 and (sw4). For $\mathcal{F}$-continuity, $[\![\Omega_t]\!] - [\![\Omega_s]\!]$ is a filling of $\Phi(t) - \Phi(s)$ modulo ∂M, so $\mathcal{F}(\Phi(t) - \Phi(s)) \leq \mathcal{H}^{n+1}(\Omega_t \triangle \Omega_s) \to 0$ by (sw2). □

Definition 1.2.16 (Good sweepout)**.** A sweepout $\{\Omega_t\}$ of $(U, \partial_F U)$ is a *good sweepout* if there exists $\varepsilon > 0$ such that

$$\mathrm{Per}(\Omega_t) \leq 5\,\mathbf{M}(\partial_I U) \quad \text{for all } t \in [0,\varepsilon) \cup (1-\varepsilon, 1].$$

We write $W_g(U)$ for the infimum of heights over all good sweepouts.

Definition 1.2.17 (Nested sweepout)**.** A sweepout $\{\Omega_t\}$ of $(U, \partial_F U)$ is *nested* if $\Omega_s \subset \Omega_t$ for all $0 \leq s \leq t \leq 1$. Equivalently, $\{\Omega_t\}$ arises from a ∂-transverse Morse function $f : M \to \mathbb{R}$ via $\Omega_t = f^{-1}((-\infty, c_t))$ for some increasing function $t \mapsto c_t$. We denote the collection of nested sweepouts of U by $\mathcal{S}_n(U)$, and write $W_n(U) := \inf_{S\in\mathcal{S}_n(U)} F(S)$.

Definition 1.2.18 (Relative sweepout and relative width)**.** A *relative sweepout* of U is a sweepout $\{\Omega_t\}$ of $(U, \partial_F U)$ with the additional property that $\partial^*\Omega_t \subset \overline{U}$ for all $t \in [0,1]$. We denote the collection of relative sweepouts by $\mathcal{S}_\partial(U)$, and define the *relative width* as $W_\partial(U) := \inf_{S\in\mathcal{S}_\partial(U)} F(S)$.

By Proposition 1.2.15, each of the above sweepout classes (good, nested, relative) gives rise to an $\mathcal{F}$-continuous map into $\mathcal{Z}_n(M, \partial M; \mathbb{Z}_2)$ satisfying the no mass concentration condition, so the min-max machinery of Li–Zhou [LZ21] applies to each corresponding width.

Proposition 1.2.19 (Width inequalities)**.** *Let $U \subset M$ be a bounded open set with smooth boundary. Then:*

(i) $W_\partial(U) \le W_n(U) \le W_\partial(U) + \mathbf{M}(\partial_I U)$;

(ii) $W_n(U) = W(U)$, *where* $W(U)$ *is the width over all sweepouts;*

(iii) *If* U *is a good set (Definition 1.2.20 below), then* $W_g(U) = W(U)$.

Proof. Part (i) follows by restricting a nested sweepout to $\overline{U}$ (giving the lower bound) and extending a relative sweepout by adding $\partial_I U$ at each time (giving the upper bound). Part (ii) is proved by approximating an arbitrary sweepout by nested ones using the coarea formula; see [CL20, Lemma 4.2]. Part (iii) follows from (ii) by a cut-off argument using the good set condition. □

Definition 1.2.20 (Good set)**.** A bounded open subset $U \subset M$ of finite perimeter is a *good set* if

$$\mathbf{M}(\partial_I U) \le \frac{1}{10} W_\partial(U),$$

where $\partial_I U = \partial[\![U]\!] \llcorner \mathrm{int}(M)$ is the interior boundary of U.

Lemma 1.2.21 (Existence of good sets)**.** *Let* (M^{n+1}, g) *be a complete Riemannian manifold with non-empty boundary and sublinear volume growth, i.e.*

$$\liminf_{R\to\infty} \frac{\mathcal{H}^{n+1}(B_R(x) \cap M)}{R} = 0 \qquad \textit{for some } x \in M.$$

Then there exists a good set $U \subset M$ *with* $0 < W_g(U) < \infty$.

Proof. Fix a point $x \in M$ and a radius $r > 0$ such that the local isoperimetric constant

$$C_I := \inf\big\{\mathbf{M}(\partial_I E) : E \subset B_r(x),\ \mathcal{H}^{n+1}(E) = \tfrac{1}{2}\,\mathcal{H}^{n+1}(B_r(x))\big\} > 0.$$

Let $d_x : M \to [0, \infty)$ denote the distance function from x. Applying the coarea inequality (Lemma 1.2.8) with $\Omega = M \cap B_S(x)$ and $f = d_x$ (noting $|\nabla d_x| \leq 1$), we obtain

$$\int_0^S \mathcal{H}^n(d_x^{-1}(R) \cap \mathrm{int}(M))\, dR \leq \mathcal{H}^{n+1}(M \cap B_S(x))$$

for any $S > 0$. The sublinear growth assumption therefore allows us to pick a regular value $R > r$ such that

$$\mathcal{H}^n(d_x^{-1}(R) \cap \mathrm{int}(M)) \leq \frac{C_I}{100}.$$

Set $U := B_R(x) \cap M$. Since $\partial_I U \subset d_x^{-1}(R) \cap \mathrm{int}(M)$, we have $\mathbf{M}(\partial_I U) \leq C_I/100$. Any sweepout of U must bisect volume in $B_r(x)$ at some time, so $W_\partial(U) \geq C_I$. Since $\mathbf{M}(\partial_I U) \leq \frac{1}{10} W_\partial(U)$, the set U is good. Finiteness $W_g(U) < \infty$ follows from the existence of a sweepout by level sets $\{d_x < R'\}$ for $R' \in [0, R]$. □

1.3 MORSE FOLIATIONS WITH CONTROLLED AREA OF FIBERS

The goal of this section is to develop technical tools for constructing *nested* sweepouts from arbitrary sweepouts. The central problem is the following: given a sweepout $\{\Omega_t\}$ that may not be nested (i.e., $\Omega_s \not\subset \Omega_t$ for $s < t$), how can we deform it into a nested sweepout while controlling the area of the level sets?

A smooth function $f\colon M \to \mathbb{R}$ is ∂-*transverse* if $f|_{\partial M}$ has no critical points, i.e. $\nabla_{\partial M}(f|_{\partial M}) \neq 0$ everywhere on ∂M; a ∂-*transverse Morse function* is a Morse function on M that is also ∂-transverse. By standard transversality theory (Hirsch [Hir76, Chapter 4]), the set of ∂-transverse Morse functions is residual in $C^\infty(M, \mathbb{R})$, since both the Morse condition and ∂-transversality are open and dense. Moreover, ∂-transversality is preserved under sufficiently small perturbations; since the perturbations in the proofs

below are either supported in $\mathrm{int}(M)$ or arbitrarily small, the ∂-transverse condition is maintained throughout.

The ∂-transverse condition ensures that level sets $f^{-1}(t)$ meet ∂M transversally, so $\mathcal{H}^n(f^{-1}(t) \cap \partial M) = 0$ and the area $\mathcal{H}^n(f^{-1}(t))$ counts only the interior part. Consequently, all results in this section follow Chambers–Liokumovich [CL20, §3–4] without essential modification. The key technical results are Lemma 1.3.1 and Lemma 1.3.2, which show that given any ∂-transverse Morse function f and a target hypersurface Σ, one can perturb f to a new Morse function g having Σ as a level set while preserving area bounds. These local constructions are glued together in Section 1.5 to produce global nested sweepouts.

Lemma 1.3.1. *Let $N^{n+1} \subset M^{n+1}$ be a compact submanifold with non-empty boundary. Let $f : N \to [a, b]$ be a ∂-transverse Morse function. Let Σ^n be a closed submanifold of ∂N.*

For every $\varepsilon > 0$, there exists a Morse function $g : N \to [a, b]$, such that the following holds:

(1) $g^{-1}(b) = \Sigma$;

(2) $f^{-1}([a, t)) \subset N_{\varepsilon/2}(g^{-1}([a, t))) \subset N_\varepsilon(f^{-1}([a, t)))$;

(3) $\mathcal{H}^n(g^{-1}(t)) \leq \mathcal{H}^n(\partial_I f^{-1}([a, t])) + \varepsilon$;

(4) If $\mathbf{dist}(x, f(\Sigma)) > \varepsilon$ *then* $f^{-1}(x) = g^{-1}(x)$.

We will also need a slightly different version of this lemma for a non-compact submanifold N.

Lemma 1.3.2. *Let $N \subset M$ be a not necessarily compact submanifold with non-empty boundary and $f : N \to (-\infty, b]$ be a proper ∂-transverse Morse function. Let Σ be a compact submanifold of ∂N.*

For every $\varepsilon > 0$ there exists a Morse function $g : N \to (-\infty, b]$, such that the following holds:

(1) $g^{-1}(b) = \Sigma$;

(2) $f^{-1}((-\infty,t)) \subset N_{\varepsilon/2}(g^{-1}((-\infty,t))) \subset N_\varepsilon(f^{-1}((-\infty,t)))$;

(3) $\mathcal{H}^n(g^{-1}(t)) \leq \mathcal{H}^n(\partial_I f^{-1}((-\infty,t])) + \varepsilon$;

(4) If $\mathbf{dist}(x, f(\Sigma)) > \varepsilon$ *then* $f^{-1}(x) = g^{-1}(x)$.

Lemma 1.3.3. *Let $N^{n+1} \subset M^{n+1}$ be a manifold with compact boundary ∂N and Σ be a hypersurface with $\partial\Sigma \subset \partial N$ and such that Σ intersects ∂N transversally and separates N into two disjoint regions $N \backslash \Sigma = V_1 \sqcup V_2$.*

For every $\varepsilon > 0$, there exist open sets with smooth boundary Ω_1 and Ω_2 and a Morse function $g : \mathrm{cl}(N \backslash (\Omega_1 \cup \Omega_2)) \to [0,1]$, such that the following holds:

(1) *Ω_1 is a relative inward ε-perturbation of V_1; Ω_2 is a relative inward ε-perturbation of V_2.*

(2) $g^{-1}(0) = \partial\Omega_1 \cup \partial\Omega_2$ *and* $g^{-1}(1) = \partial N$;

(3) $\mathcal{H}^n(g^{-1}(t)) \leq \mathbf{M}(\partial_I N) + 2\,\mathcal{H}^n(\Sigma) + \varepsilon$.

Proof. Let $f : M \to \mathbb{R}$ be a ∂-transverse Morse function such that there exists some sufficiently small $0 < \delta_1 < \varepsilon$,

$$f(x) = \mathrm{sdist}(x, \partial N)$$

for $x \in N_{\delta_1}(\partial N)$. The sign is chosen so that $f(x) \geq 0$ when $x \in N$. Without any loss of generality, we may assume the following three conditions hold:

(i) f has no critical points in the ε-neighborhood of Σ: a generic Morse function has no critical points on any given compact set, so a small perturbation of f (supported away from $N_{\delta_1}(\partial N)$) achieves this.

(ii) The restriction $f|_\Sigma$ is also Morse: by Sard's theorem, $f|_\Sigma$ is Morse for a generic choice of f.

(iii) The mass bound

$$\mathcal{H}^n(f^{-1}(t)) \leq \mathbf{M}(\partial_I N) + \varepsilon/10$$

holds for $t \in [0, \delta_1]$: since $f = \mathrm{sdist}(\cdot, \partial N)$ in $N_{\delta_1}(\partial N)$, the level set $f^{-1}(t)$ converges to ∂N in the C^1 sense as $t \to 0$, so $\mathcal{H}^n(f^{-1}(t) \cap N)$ converges to $\mathcal{H}^n(\partial_I N)$, and we can choose δ_1 small enough for this bound to hold.

Pick $\delta_2 \in (0, \delta_1)$ so that for $t \in (0, \delta_2)$,

$$\mathcal{H}^n(f^{-1}(t) \cap N_{\delta_2}(\Sigma)) < \varepsilon/10$$

and

$$\mathcal{H}^n(\partial N_{\delta_2}(\Sigma)) \leq 2\,\mathcal{H}^n(\Sigma) + \varepsilon/10.$$

Let Ω_i denote a relative inward $\delta_2/2$-perturbation of V_i, i.e.

(a) $V_i \backslash N_{\delta_2/2}(\partial V_i) \subset \Omega_i \subsetneq V_i$;

(b) there exists a nested family of open sets $\{\Xi_t^i\}_{t \in [0,1]}$ and corresponding smooth isotopies $\partial \Xi_t^i$, such that $\partial \Xi_1^i$ is a smoothing of ∂V_i and

$$\mathcal{H}^n(\partial \Xi_t^i) \leq \mathcal{H}^n(\partial V_i) + \delta_2/2$$

for all $t \in [0, 1]$.

We can make an arbitrarily small perturbation of f by an ambient diffeomorphism so that f is a Morse function on $\partial\Omega_1 \cup \partial\Omega_2$. For $t \in [0, \delta_2]$, since $f = \mathrm{sdist}(\cdot, \partial N)$ in $N_{\delta_1}(\partial N)$, the level set $f^{-1}(t)$ is C^1-close to ∂N. In particular, each leaf $\Sigma_t = (f^{-1}(t) \cap N) \backslash (\Omega_1 \cup \Omega_2)$ is a normal graph over some region $U_t \subset \partial N$, with

$$\mathcal{H}^n(\Sigma_t) \leq \mathcal{H}^n(U_t) + \varepsilon/5$$

It follows that

$$\mathcal{H}^n(f^{-1}(t) \cap \mathrm{cl}(N \setminus (\Omega_1 \cup \Omega_2))) \leq 2\,\mathcal{H}^n(\Sigma) + \mathbf{M}(\partial_I N) + \varepsilon/2.$$

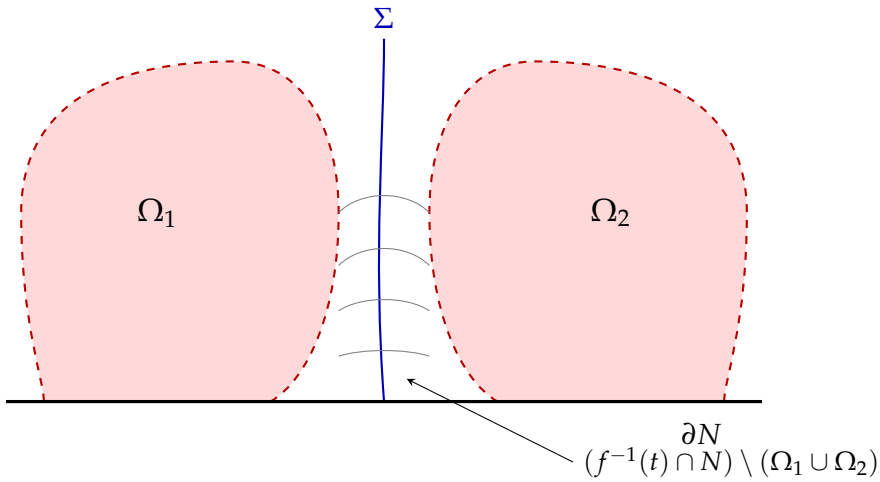

Figure 1.2: Gluing two submanifolds using a Morse function. The hypersurface Σ (blue) separates N into two regions; Ω_1 and Ω_2 (shaded) are inward perturbations of these regions. The foliation leaves (gray) in the gap $N \setminus (\Omega_1 \cup \Omega_2)$ connect $\partial\Omega_1 \cup \partial\Omega_2$ to ∂N.

We now verify that the hypotheses of Lemma 1.3.2 are satisfied for the restriction $f|_{N\setminus(\Omega_1\cup\Omega_2)}$:

- The domain $N' = \mathrm{cl}(N \setminus (\Omega_1 \cup \Omega_2))$ is a (non-compact) manifold with boundary $\partial N' = \partial\Omega_1 \cup \partial\Omega_2 \cup \partial N$.
- $f|_{N'}$ is proper: preimages of compact sets in $[0, \delta_1]$ are compact since the non-compact ends (i.e. the interiors of V_1 and V_2) have been removed by excising Ω_1 and Ω_2.
- $f|_{N'}$ is ∂-transverse on N', as this is inherited from the ∂-transversality of f on N.
- $\partial\Omega_1 \cup \partial\Omega_2$ plays the role of Σ in Lemma 1.3.2, i.e. the compact submanifold of $\partial N'$ sent to $b = \delta_1$.

Applying Lemma 1.3.2, we obtain the desired function g and the corresponding foliation, i.e.

$$\mathcal{H}^n(g^{-1}(t)) \leq 2\,\mathcal{H}^n(\Sigma) + \mathbf{M}(\partial_I N) + \varepsilon.$$

□

1.4 SPLITTING AND EXTENSION LEMMAS

This section develops two fundamental technical tools needed for the construction of nested sweepouts: the *extension lemma* and the *splitting lemma*. The extension lemma allows us to modify a nested family of hypersurfaces to accommodate a new endpoint hypersurface while controlling the mass increase. The splitting lemma, based on Falconer's projection theorem, enables us to construct a nested family connecting two nested regions with controlled slice masses.

The Extension Lemma

The extension lemma is a key ingredient in the monotonisation algorithm. It allows us to insert or remove a hypersurface at one endpoint of a nested family while keeping the mass bounded.

Lemma 1.4.1. *Suppose that $f : M \to [-1, \infty)$ is a ∂-transverse Morse function and $\{\Gamma_t\} = \{f^{-1}(t)\}_{t\in[0,1]}$ is a nested family of hypersurfaces such that $\mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma_t) \leq A$ for all $t \in [0,1]$ with associated open sets $\{\Omega_t\} = \{f^{-1}((-\infty, t))\}$.*

I. *Suppose Ω is a bounded open set with boundary Γ a smooth embedded manifold such that*

   (1) $\Omega \subset \Omega_1$;

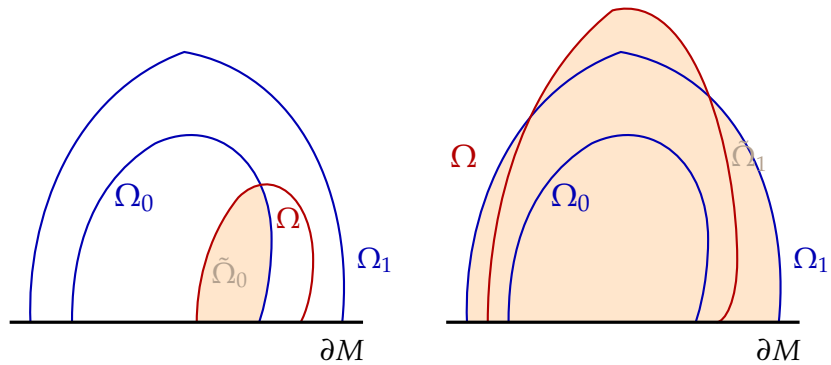

Figure 1.3: Illustration of Lemma 1.4.1. **Left** (Case I, $\Omega \neq \Omega_0$): Ω_0 and Ω partially overlap, with $\Omega \subset \Omega_1$. The shaded region $\tilde{\Omega}_0 = \Omega \cap \Omega_0$ serves as the new starting set for the modified nested family. **Right** (Case II, $\Omega \neq \Omega_1$): $\Omega_0 \subset \Omega$, and Ω partially overlaps Ω_1. The shaded region $\tilde{\Omega}_1 = \Omega \cup \Omega_1$ serves as the new ending set for the modified nested family.

(2) *There is an $\varepsilon > 0$ such that for every Ω' with $\Omega \subset \Omega' \subset \Omega_1$ we have*

$$\mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma) < \mathbf{M}(\partial_I \Omega') + \frac{\varepsilon}{4}.$$

Then, we can find a nested family $\{\tilde{\Gamma}_t\}$ and an associated family of open sets $\{\tilde{\Omega}_t\}$ such that $\tilde{\Omega}_0 \subset \Omega_0$, $\tilde{\Gamma}_1 = \Gamma$ and for all $t \in [0,1]$

$$\mathcal{H}^n(\tilde{\Gamma}_t) \leq A + \varepsilon.$$

Furthermore, if $\Omega_0 \subset \Omega$, then $\tilde{\Gamma}_0 = \Gamma_0$.

II. *Suppose that instead of properties (1) and (2) above, the following are true:*

(1)′ $\Omega_0 \subset \Omega$;

(2)′ *There is an $\varepsilon > 0$ such that for every Ω' with $\Omega_0 \subset \Omega' \subset \Omega$ we have*

$$\mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma) < \mathbf{M}(\partial_I \Omega') + \frac{\varepsilon}{4}.$$

Then, we can find a nested family $\{\tilde{\Gamma}_t\}$ *and an associated family of open sets* $\{\tilde{\Omega}_t\}$ *such that* $\Omega_1 \subset \tilde{\Omega}_1$, $\tilde{\Omega}_0 = \Gamma$, *and for all* $t \in [0,1]$

$$\mathcal{H}^n(\tilde{\Gamma}_t) \leq A + \varepsilon.$$

Furthermore, if $\Omega \subset \Omega_1$, *then* $\tilde{\Gamma}_1 = \Gamma_1$.

Proof. We begin the proof with the first half of this lemma. The desired family will be obtained by regularization of the collection of hypersurfaces $\{\partial(\Omega_0 \cap \Omega)\}$. As in the left side of Figure 1.3.

- **Case I(a)** $\Omega \subset \Omega_0$**:**
  For a sufficiently small $\delta > 0$ the function $g : \mathrm{cl}(N_\delta(\Gamma) \cap \Omega) \to [0,1]$ given by $g(x) = \frac{1}{\delta}\mathbf{dist}(x, \Gamma)$ is a smooth function without critical points and $\tilde{\Gamma}_t = g^{-1}(t)$ would satisfy

  $$\mathcal{H}^n(\tilde{\Gamma}_t) \leq \mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma) + \frac{\varepsilon}{2}.$$

  By I(2) and $\Omega \subset \Omega_0 \subset \Omega_1$, we know that

  $$\mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma) \leq \mathbf{M}(\partial_I \Omega_0) + \frac{\varepsilon}{4}$$

  thus

  $$\mathcal{H}^n(\tilde{\Gamma}_t) \leq A + \varepsilon.$$

  We extend g to a ∂-transverse Morse function on M in an arbitrary way and $\{\tilde{\Gamma}_t\}$ is a nested family satisfying the conditions of the theorem.

- **Case I(b)** $\Omega \backslash \Omega_0 \neq \varnothing$**:**
  Make a small perturbation to the hypersurface $\Gamma = \partial\Omega$ so that $f|_{\partial\Omega}$ is a Morse and (1) and (2) are still satisfied, possibly replacing $\varepsilon/4$ in (2) by $\varepsilon/2$.

Consider f restricted to Ω. We apply Lemma 1.3.1 with $N = \Omega$ and $\Sigma = \Gamma$ to obtain a Morse function $g : \Omega \to [-1, 1]$ for $\varepsilon/2$ such that $g^{-1}(-1)$ is a point in Ω and

1. $g^{-1}(1) = \Gamma$;
2. $f^{-1}([-1, t)) \subset N_{\varepsilon/4}(g^{-1}([-1, t))) \subset N_{\varepsilon/2}(f^{-1}([-1, t)))$;
3. $\mathcal{H}^n(g^{-1}(t)) \leq \mathcal{H}^n(\partial_I f^{-1}([-1, t])) + \varepsilon/2$;
4. If $\mathbf{dist}(x, f(\Gamma)) \geq \varepsilon/2$ then $f^{-1}(x) = g^{-1}(x)$.

It follows from 3. that

$$\begin{aligned}\mathcal{H}^n(g^{-1}(t)) \leq & \mathcal{H}^n(f^{-1}(t) \cap \Omega) \\ & + \mathcal{H}^n(f^{-1}([-1, t]) \cap \Gamma) + \frac{\varepsilon}{2}\end{aligned}$$

Furthermore, we have

$$g^{-1}([-1, 0)) \subset N_\varepsilon(\Omega \cap \Omega_0).$$

After a small perturbation of the function g we may assume that $g^{-1}([-1, 0)) \subset (\Omega \cap \Omega_0)$. We can extend g to a Morse function in an arbitrary way. We claim that $\tilde{\Gamma}_t = g^{-1}(t)$ for $t \in [0, 1]$ is the desired nested family and the only thing left is to prove the upper bound for the areas of $\tilde{\Gamma}_t$.

For any smooth hypersurface Σ_t obtained by a small perturbation of $\partial(\Omega \cup \Omega_t)$ since $\Omega \subset (\Omega \cup \Omega_t) \subset \Omega_1$. It follows that

$$\mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma) \leq \mathcal{H}^n(\Sigma_t) + \frac{\varepsilon}{4}$$

Furthermore, it follows that

$$\mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma) \leq \mathbf{M}(\partial_I(\Omega \cup \Omega_t)) + \frac{\varepsilon}{2}$$

Since $\partial(\Omega \cup \Omega_t) = (\Gamma_t \backslash \Omega) \cup (\Gamma \backslash \Omega_t)$ we have

$$\begin{aligned} &\mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma \cap \Omega_t) + \mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma \backslash \Omega_t) \\ &\leq \mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma_t \backslash \Omega) + \mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma \backslash \Omega_t) + \varepsilon/2 \\ \implies &\mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma \cap \Omega_t) \leq \mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma_t \backslash \Omega) + \varepsilon/2 \end{aligned}$$

By Lemma 1.3.1, we have

$$\begin{aligned} \mathcal{H}^n(\tilde{\Gamma}_t) \leq &\mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma_t \cap \Omega) + \mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma \cap \Omega_t) + \frac{\varepsilon}{2} \\ \leq &\mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma_t \cap \Omega) + \mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma_t \backslash \Omega) + \varepsilon \\ \leq &\mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma_t) + \varepsilon \leq A + \varepsilon \end{aligned}$$

If $\Omega_0 \subset \Omega$, then by choosing sufficiently small $\varepsilon > 0$ and applying Lemma 1.3.1(4), we have

$$\tilde{\Gamma}_0 = f^{-1}(0) = \Gamma_0.$$

The proof of the second half is similar. The desired family will be a regularization of $\{\partial(\Omega_t \cup \Omega)\}$.

- **Case II(a) $\Omega_1 \subset \Omega$:**
  We define the desired nested family $\{\tilde{\Gamma}_t\}$ in a small tubular neighbourhood of Γ.

- **Case II(b) $\Omega_1 \backslash \Omega \neq \varnothing$:** We define $\tilde{f}(x) = -f(x)$. We apply Lemma 1.3.2 to $N = M \backslash \Omega$ and $\Sigma = \Gamma$ and the restriction $\tilde{f} : M \backslash \Omega \to (-\infty, 0]$. It follows that given $\varepsilon/2$, there exists a Morse function $\tilde{g} : M \backslash \Omega \to (-\infty, 0]$, such that

  1. $\tilde{g}^{-1}(0) = \Gamma$;
  2. $\tilde{f}^{-1}((-\infty, t)) \subset N_{\varepsilon/4}(\tilde{g}^{-1}((-\infty, t))) \subset N_{\varepsilon/2}(\tilde{f}^{-1}((-\infty, t)))$;
  3. $\mathcal{H}^n(\tilde{g}^{-1}(t)) \leq \mathcal{H}^n(\partial_I \tilde{f}^{-1}((-\infty, t])) + \frac{\varepsilon}{2}$;
  4. If $\mathbf{dist}(x, \tilde{f}(\Sigma)) > \varepsilon$ then $\tilde{f}^{-1}(x) = \tilde{g}^{-1}(x)$.

We define $g(x) = -\tilde{g}(x)$ for $x \in M \backslash \Omega$ and extend it to a ∂-transverse Morse function from M to $[-1, \infty)$ in an arbitrary way. By property (2) of Lemma 1.3.2 we take that (possibly after a small perturbation)

$$\tilde{\Omega}_1 := g^{-1}([-1, 1]) \supset \Omega_1$$

For any smooth hypersurface Σ_t obtained by a small perturbation of $\partial(\Omega \cap \Omega_t)$. By (2)′, we have

$$\mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma) \leq \mathcal{H}^n(\Sigma_t) + \frac{\varepsilon}{4}$$

Furthermore, it follows that

$$\mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma) \leq \mathbf{M}(\partial_I(\Omega \cap \Omega_t)) + \frac{\varepsilon}{2}$$

Since $\partial(\Omega \cap \Omega_t) = (\Gamma_t \cap \Omega) \cup (\Gamma \cap \Omega_t)$ we have

$$\begin{aligned} &\mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma \cap \Omega_t) + \mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma \backslash \Omega_t) \\ &\leq \mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma_t \cap \Omega) + \mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma \cap \Omega_t) + \varepsilon/2 \\ \Longrightarrow\ &\mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma \backslash \Omega_t) \leq \mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma_t \cap \Omega) + \varepsilon/2 \end{aligned}$$

By Lemma 1.3.2, we have

$$\begin{aligned} \mathcal{H}^n(\tilde{\Gamma}_t) \leq &\mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma_t \backslash \Omega) + \mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma \backslash \Omega_t) + \frac{\varepsilon}{2} \\ \leq &\mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma_t \backslash \Omega) + \mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma_t \cap \Omega) + \varepsilon \\ \leq &\mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma_t) + \varepsilon \leq A + \varepsilon \end{aligned}$$

If $\Omega \subset \Omega_1$ then by property (4) of Lemma 1.3.2 we may assume that $\tilde{\Gamma}_1 = g^{-1}(1) = \Gamma_1$. $\square$

The Splitting Lemma

The second lemma in this section deals with constructing a nested family between two nested open sets.

Theorem 1.4.2 (Falconer)**.** *There exists a constant $C(n)$ so that the following is true. Let $U \subset \mathbb{R}^{n+1}$ be an open set with smooth boundary. There exists a line $l \in \mathbb{R}^{n+1}$ so that the projection p_l onto l satisfies*

$$\mathbf{Vol}_n(U \cap p_l^{-1}(t)) < C(n)\mathbf{Vol}_{n+1}(U)^{\frac{n}{n+1}}$$

for all $t \in l$. Moreover, we can assume that p_l restricted to ∂U is a Morse function.

Lemma 1.4.3. *Let $\varepsilon > 0$, $L > 0$. Suppose $\Omega_0 \subset \Omega_1$ be bounded open sets with smooth boundary and $\Omega_1 \backslash \Omega_0 \subset B$ where B is $(1+L)$-bilipschitz diffeomorphic to a relative open subset U of $\mathbb{R}^{n+1}_+$. There exists a constant $C(n)$ and a nested family $\{\Gamma'_t\}$ with a family of corresponding open sets $\{\Omega'_t\}$, such that*

(1) the mass of the new sweepout can be estimated as

$$\begin{aligned}\mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma'_t) \leq & \mathbf{M}(\partial_I \Omega_0) + \mathbf{M}(\partial_I(\Omega_1 \backslash \Omega_0)) \\ & + C(n)(1+L)^n \mathcal{H}^{n+1}(\Omega_1 \backslash \Omega_0)^{\frac{n}{n+1}} + \varepsilon;\end{aligned}$$

(2) Ω'_0 is a relative inward ε-perturbation of Ω_0 and $\Omega'_1 = \Omega_1$;

(2′) Ω'_1 is a relative outward ε-perturbation of Ω_1 and $\Omega'_0 = \Omega_0$;

Proof. Let Ω' be a relative inward $\varepsilon/8$-perturbation of $\Omega = \Omega_1 \backslash \Omega_0$. By definition that means

(a) $\Omega \backslash N_{\frac{\varepsilon}{8}}(\partial\Omega) \subset \Omega' \subsetneq \Omega$;

(b) There exists a nested family of open sets $\{\Xi_t\}_{t \in [0,1]}$ and a smooth isotopy $\Sigma_t = \partial \Xi_t$, such that Σ_0 is a smoothing of $\partial\Omega$ and $\Xi_1 = \Omega'$ such that

$$\mathcal{H}^n(\Sigma_t) \leq \mathbf{M}(\partial_I \Omega) + \frac{\varepsilon}{8}$$

for all $t \in [0,1]$.

By Theorem 1.4.2, there exists a Morse function $f : \Omega' \to [0,1]$ such that

$$\mathcal{H}^n(f^{-1}(t)) \leq C(n)(1+L)^n \mathcal{H}^{n+1}(\Omega_1 \backslash \Omega_0)^{\frac{n}{n+1}} + \varepsilon/4.$$

We denote the nested sweepout of Ω' from g as $\{\Sigma_t^a\}$ with the corresponding family of open sets $\{\Xi_t^a\}$, such that $\Omega' = \Xi_1^a$. By Lemma 1.3.1, given $\varepsilon/4 > 0$, we can find $g : \Omega' \to [0,1]$ such that

$$\begin{aligned} \mathcal{H}^n(\Sigma_t^a) &\leq \mathbf{M}(\partial_I f^{-1}([0,t])) + \varepsilon/4 \\ &\leq \mathbf{M}(\partial_I(\Omega_1 \backslash \Omega_0)) + C(n)(1+L)^n \mathcal{H}^{n+1}(\Omega_1 \backslash \Omega_0)^{\frac{n}{n+1}} + \varepsilon/2. \end{aligned} \tag{1.1}$$

Let $\{\Sigma_t^b\}$ be a nested family with a corresponding family of open sets $\{\Xi_t^b\}$, such that $\{\Xi_0^b\}$ is a relative inward $\varepsilon/2$-perturbation of Ω_0, Ξ_1^b is a relative inward $\varepsilon/8$-perturbation of Ω_0. For all $t \in [0,1]$, the mass of the slices would satisfy

$$\mathcal{H}^n(\Sigma_t^b) \leq \mathbf{M}(\partial_I \Omega_0) + \varepsilon/2. \tag{1.2}$$

By Lemma 1.3.3, there exists a nested family $\{\Sigma_t^c\}$ with the corresponding family of open sets $\{\Xi_t^c\}$, such that $\Xi_1^c = \Omega_1$, $\Xi_0^c = \Xi^1 \sqcup \Xi^2$, where Ξ^1 is a relative inward $\varepsilon/8$-perturbation of Ω_0 and Ξ^2 is a relative inward $\varepsilon/8$-perturbation of $\Omega_1 \backslash \Omega_0$. It follows from the properties of the perturbations that, without any loss of generality, we may assume $\Xi^1 = \Xi_1^b$ and $\Xi^2 = \Omega'$. By (3) of Lemma 1.3.3, we have

$$\begin{aligned} \mathcal{H}^n(\Sigma_t^c) \leq& \mathbf{M}(\partial_I \Omega_1) + 2\,\mathcal{H}^n(\partial\Omega_0 \backslash \partial\Omega_1) + \varepsilon \\ \leq& \mathbf{M}(\partial_I(\Omega_1 \backslash \Omega_0)) + \mathbf{M}(\partial_I \Omega_0) + \varepsilon \end{aligned}$$

We define $\Gamma'_t = \Sigma^a_{2t} \cup \Sigma^b_{2t}$ for $t \in [0, 1/2)$ and $\Gamma'_t = \Sigma^c_{2t-1}$, $t \in [1/2, 1]$ with the open sets defined correspondingly. Then for $t \in [0, 1/2)$ combining 1.1 and 1.2, we obtain

$$\begin{aligned}\mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma'_t) \leq & \mathcal{H}^n(\Sigma^a_{2t}) + \mathcal{H}^n(\Sigma^b_{2t}) \\ \leq & \mathbf{M}(\partial_I \Omega_0) + \mathbf{M}(\partial_I(\Omega_1 \backslash \Omega_0)) \\ & + C(n)(1+L)^n \mathcal{H}^{n+1}(\Omega_1 \backslash \Omega_0)^{\frac{n}{n+1}} + \varepsilon\end{aligned}$$

□

1.5 NESTED SWEEPOUT

The construction of nested sweepouts is crucial for our work. As discussed in [CL20, §6], nested families allow us to glue local deformations while keeping precise control over the maximal mass of the sweepout. A family $\{\Gamma_t\}_{t\in[0,1]}$ is *nested* if it is given by the level sets of a ∂-transverse Morse function, so that the associated regions $\Omega_t = f^{-1}((-\infty, t))$ vary by elementary topological moves (handle attachments or deletions) as t increases.

The main result of this section, Proposition 1.5.1, shows that any sweepout of a bounded relative open set U can be approximated by a nested sweepout with arbitrarily small mass increase. The proof follows the strategy of [CL20, Lemma 6.2], adapted to the free-boundary setting, and proceeds in three main steps:

1. **Step 1 (Preliminary Modification):** Subdivide the original sweepout $\{\Gamma_t\}_{t\in[0,1]}$ into a finite number of subintervals $[t_i, t_{i+1}]$ such that on each subinterval, the corresponding regions Ω_t are either monotone increasing or monotone decreasing.

2. **Step 2 (Local Monotonization):** On each subinterval $[t_i, t_{i+1}]$, construct a nested family connecting slightly modified versions of Ω_{t_i}

and $\Omega_{t_{i+1}}$. This uses the splitting and extension lemmas from Section 1.4 to build explicit Morse functions whose level sets have controlled mass.

3. **Step 3 (Gluing):** Glue the nested families from adjacent intervals into a single global nested sweepout. The construction ensures that adjacent families satisfy the compatibility condition $\Omega_0^{i+1} \subset \Omega_1^i$, which allows for repeated application of a gluing proposition.

Proposition 1.5.1. *Let $U \subset M$ be a bounded relative open subset with smooth relative boundary. Then for any $\varepsilon > 0$, and any $\{\Gamma_t\} \in \mathcal{S}(U)$ with the corresponding open sets $\{\Omega_t\}$ with $\mathcal{F}(\{\Gamma_t\}) \leq A$, there exists a nested family $\{\tilde{\Gamma}_t\}$ with the corresponding family of open sets $\{\tilde{\Omega}_t\}$ such that $\tilde{\Omega}_0 \subset \Omega_0$, $\Omega_1 \subset \tilde{\Omega}_1$ with $\mathcal{F}(\{\tilde{\Gamma}_t\}) \leq A + \varepsilon$. In particular, this implies $W(U) = W_n(U)$.*

The proof of this proposition follows the strategy of [CL20, Lemma 6.2], with the following modifications for the free-boundary setting:

(i) *Boundary balls*: When a ball B_i in the covering meets ∂M, we work inside a fixed collar $\Phi : \partial M \times [0, \rho) \to M$ and regard B_i as bilipschitz to a half-ball in $\mathbb{R}^{n+1}_+$. All local deformations are generated by vector fields in $\mathfrak{X}_{\tan}(M)$, preserving the free-boundary condition.

(ii) *Relative cycles*: The sweepout takes values in $\mathbf{Z}_n(M, \partial M; \mathbb{Z}_2)$ (see Remark 1.2.2), and we use the coarea inequality (Lemma 1.2.8) to control boundary contributions.

(iii) *∂-transverse Morse functions*: The Morse functions constructed in the preliminary modification are required to be ∂-transverse (Definition 1.3), ensuring that level sets meet ∂M transversally.

Step 1: Preliminary Modification

Fix $\{\Gamma_t\} \in \mathcal{S}(U)$ with the corresponding open sets $\{\Omega_t\}$ with $\mathcal{F}(\{\Gamma_t\}) \leq A$. We apply the preliminary modification as in [CL20, Lemma 6.2] to $\{\Gamma_t\}$.

Lemma 1.5.2 (Preliminary Modification). *For any $\varepsilon > 0$ there exists a partition $0 = t_0 < \cdots < t_N = 1$ of $[0,1]$ and a family $\{\Gamma'_t\}$ with the corresponding family of open sets $\{\Omega'_t\}$, such that the following holds:*

(1.1) $\Omega'_0 \subset \Omega_0$ *and* $\Omega_1 \subset \Omega'_1$*;*

(1.2) $\mathcal{F}(\{\Gamma'_t\}) \leq \mathcal{F}(\{\Gamma_t\}) + \varepsilon$*;*

(1.3) For each $i = 0, \ldots, N-1$ we have one of the two possibilities:

- *(A)* $\Omega'_{t_i} \subset \Omega'_{t_{i+1}}$ *and there exists a Morse function* $g_i : \mathrm{cl}(\Omega_{t_{i+1}} \backslash \Omega_{t_i}) \to [t_i, t_{i+1}]$*, such that* $\Gamma'_t = g_i^{-1}(t)$ *and* $\Omega'_t = \Omega'_{t_i} \cup g_i^{-1}((-\infty, t))$ *for* $t \in [t_i, t_{i+1}]$.
- *(B)* $\Omega'_{t_{i+1}} \subset \Omega'_{t_i}$ *and there exists a Morse function* $g_i : \mathrm{cl}(\Omega_{t_i} \backslash \Omega_{t_{i+1}}) \to [t_i, t_{i+1}]$*, such that* $\Gamma'_t = g_i^{-1}(t)$ *and* $\Omega'_t = \Omega'_{t_i} \cup g_i^{-1}((-\infty, t])$ *for* $t \in [t_i, t_{i+1}]$.

Proof. Let M' be a compact subset of M that contains the closure of Ω_t for all $t \in [0,1]$.

Set $L_{\text{ball}} := (1 + \frac{\varepsilon}{100W})^{1/n} - 1$ so that $(1 + L_{\text{ball}})^n \leq 1 + \frac{\varepsilon}{100W}$.

Choose r sufficiently small so that for every ball B of radius less than or equal to r in M' the following holds:

(i) B is $(1 + L_{\text{ball}})$-bilipschitz diffeomorphic to the Euclidean ball of the same radius (or to a half-ball in $\mathbb{R}^{n+1}_+$ if B meets ∂M);

(ii) $\mathcal{H}^n(B \cap \Gamma_t) < \frac{\varepsilon}{20}$ for $t \in [0,1]$.

Condition (ii) can be realized because of the no concentration of mass property (sw4).

Boundary balls. If a ball B_i meets ∂M, we work inside a fixed collar $\Phi : \partial M \times [0, \rho) \to M$ and regard B_i as bilipschitz to a half-ball in $\mathbb{R}^{n+1}_+$. All local deformations in such B_i are generated by compactly supported vector fields in $\mathfrak{X}_{\tan}(M)$. This preserves the free-boundary condition and keeps the same bilipschitz constants as in (i).

Let $\{B_i\}$ be a collection of k balls of radius r covering M', such that balls of half the radius cover M'. We choose a partition $0 = s_0 < \cdots < s_{N'} = 1$, such that

(iii)

$$\begin{aligned}&\mathcal{H}^{n+1}(B_i \cap (\Omega_{s_j} \backslash \Omega_{s_{j+1}})) + \mathcal{H}^{n+1}(B_i \cap (\Omega_{s_{j+1}} \backslash \Omega_{s_j}))\\ &< \min\left\{\frac{r\varepsilon}{10k}, \left(\frac{\varepsilon}{10}\right)^{\frac{n+1}{n}}\right\};\end{aligned}$$

(iv) $\left|\mathcal{H}^n(B_i \cap \Gamma_{s_j}) - \mathcal{H}^n(B_i \cap \Gamma_{s_{j+1}})\right| \leq \frac{\varepsilon}{10k}$

for each $j = 0, \ldots, N'$ and $i = 1, \ldots, k$.

We define the new family $\{\Gamma'_t\}$ as follows. For $t = s_j$ we set $\Omega'_t = \Omega_t$ and $\Gamma'_t = \partial\Omega_t$ unless Γ_t is a finite collection of points in which case we set $\Gamma'_t = \Gamma_t$ and $\Omega'_t = \varnothing$.

Define a subdivision of $[s_j, s_{j+1}]$ into $2k$ subintervals, $s_j = s_j^0 < \cdots < s_j^{2k} = s_{j+1}$. Let $\{B'_i\}$ be a collection of k balls concentric with B_i of radius between $r/2$ and r and such that $\partial B'_i$ intersects Γ_{s_j} and $\Gamma_{s_{j+1}}$ transversally. Set

$$U_j^1 = \Omega_{s_j} \backslash \Omega_{s_{j+1}} \quad \text{and} \quad U_j^2 = \Omega_{s_{j+1}} \backslash \Omega_{s_j}.$$

By the coarea inequality (Lemma 1.2.8) and (iii), we may assume B'_i satisfies

$$\mathcal{H}^n(\partial B'_i \cap (U_j^1 \cup U_j^2)) \leq \frac{\varepsilon}{4k}. \tag{1.3}$$

Since the balls of radius $r/2$ already cover M', and each B_i' has radius in $[r/2, r]$ and is concentric with B_i, the family $\{B_i'\}_{i=1}^k$ still covers M'. Inductively we define

$$\begin{aligned} \Omega'_{s_j^0} &= \Omega'_{s_j} \\ \Omega'_{s_j^{2i-1}} &= \Omega'_{s_j^{2i-2}} \backslash (B_i' \cap U_j^1) \\ \Omega'_{s_j^{2i}} &= \Omega'_{s_j^{2i-1}} \cup (B_i' \cap U_j^2) \end{aligned} \tag{1.4}$$

for $i = 1, \ldots, k$.

Surfaces $\partial\Omega'_{s_j^l}$ may not be smooth, but there exists an arbitrarily small perturbation so that the boundaries are smooth. We perform these perturbations in the inward direction for $\Omega'_{s_j^{2i-1}}$ and in the outward direction for $\Omega'_{s_j^{2i}}$. To simplify notation we do not rename the sets after the perturbations; since the perturbations are arbitrarily small all the estimates for masses and volumes remain valid.

The following properties follow from the definition 1.4 and (i)-(ii):

(a) $\left| \mathbf{M}(\partial_I \Omega'_{s_j^l}) - \mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma_{s_j}) \right| < \varepsilon/2$;

(b) $\Omega'_{s_j^{2i-1}} \subset \Omega'_{s_j^{2i}}$ and $\Omega'_{s_j^{2i-1}} \subset \Omega'_{s_j^{2i-2}}$.

We define $\Gamma'_{s_j^l} = \partial\Omega'_{s_j^l}$, unless $\Omega'_{s_j^l}$ is empty.

If $\Omega'_{s_j^l}$ is empty we set $\Gamma'_{s_j^l}$ to be a point inside $\Omega'_{s_j^{l-1}}$. By properties (iii) and (iv) surface $\Gamma'_{s_j^l}$ will satisfy the desired upper bound on the mass.

To complete our construction we need to show the existence of two types of nested families:

- a nested family that starts on $\Gamma'_{s_j^{2i-1}}$ and ends on $\Gamma'_{s_j^{2i-2}}$;
- a nested family that starts on $\Gamma'_{s_j^{2i-1}}$ and ends on $\Gamma'_{s_j^{2i}}$.

In both cases we want the homotopies to satisfy the desired upper bound on the masses.

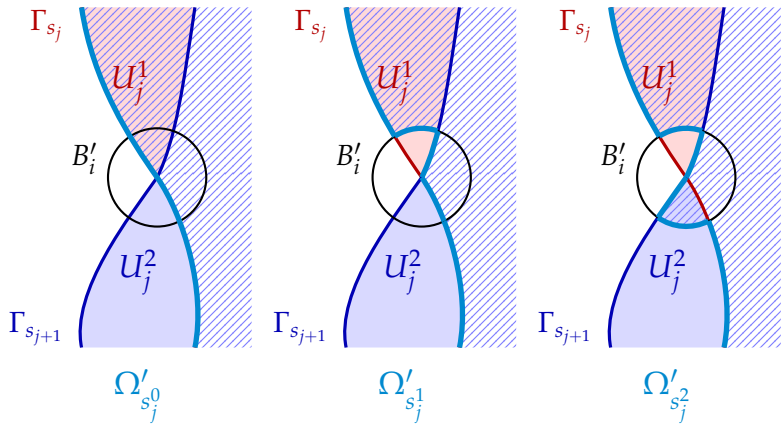

Figure 1.4: Construction of $\Omega'_{s_j^{2i-2}}$, $\Omega'_{s_j^{2i-1}}$, $\Omega'_{s_j^{2i}}$ for $i = 1$. The two curves Γ_{s_j} (red) and $\Gamma_{s_{j+1}}$ (blue) cross near B_i', creating $U_j^1 = \Omega_{s_j} \setminus \Omega_{s_{j+1}}$ (red, hatched) and $U_j^2 = \Omega_{s_{j+1}} \setminus \Omega_{s_j}$ (blue). **Left**: $\Omega'_{s_j^0} = \Omega'_{s_j}$. **Middle**: $\Omega'_{s_j^1} = \Omega'_{s_j^0} \setminus (B_i' \cap U_j^1)$; the hatched part inside B_i' is removed. **Right**: $\Omega'_{s_j^2} = \Omega'_{s_j^1} \cup (B_i' \cap U_j^2)$; the blue part inside B_i' is added.

Consider the set $\Omega'_{s_j^{2i-2}} \setminus \Omega'_{s_j^{2i-1}} = B_i' \cap U_j^1$. After smoothing the corner we call this set U. We map B_i' to $\mathbb{R}^{n+1}$ by a $(1 + L_{\text{ball}})$-bilipschitz diffeomorphism. Existence of the desired nested families follows by Lemma 1.4.3. The upper bound for the mass follows from the upper bound at the endpoints and properties (i) and (ii).

$$\begin{aligned}
\mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma_t') \leq & \mathbf{M}(\partial_I \Omega'_{s_j^{2i-1}}) + \mathbf{M}(\partial_I(\Omega'_{s_j^{2i-2}} \setminus \Omega'_{s_j^{2i-1}})) \\
& + C(n)(1 + L_{\text{ball}})^n \mathcal{H}^{n+1}(\Omega'_{s_j^{2i-2}} \setminus \Omega'_{s_j^{2i-1}}) + \varepsilon \\
\leq & \mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma_{s_j}) + \varepsilon/2 + \varepsilon/10 + \varepsilon/4k \\
& + C(n)(1 + L_{\text{ball}})^n \min\left\{ \frac{r\varepsilon}{10k}, (\frac{\varepsilon}{10})^{\frac{n+1}{n}} \right\} \\
\leq & \mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma_{s_j}) + \varepsilon
\end{aligned}$$

□

Step 2: Local Monotonization

Assume that family $\{\Gamma_t\}$ satisfies conclusions of Lemma 1.5.2 for the subdivision $0 = t_0 < \cdots < t_N = 1$.

For every $\varepsilon > 0$ and each $i = 0, \ldots, N-1$, we will inductively define sets Ω_0^i and Ω_1^i such that the following holds:

(2.1) $\Omega_0^i \subset \Omega_1^i$;

(2.2) $\max\left\{\mathbf{M}(\partial_I \Omega_0^i), \mathbf{M}(\partial_I \Omega_1^i)\right\}$
$\leq \max\left\{\mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma_{t_i}), \mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma_{t_{i+1}})\right\} + \varepsilon$;

(2.3) $\Omega_{t_{i+1}} \subset \Omega_1^i$ and $\Omega_0^i \subset \Omega_{t_i}$;

(2.4) There exists a nested family of hypersurfaces $\left\{\Gamma_t^i\right\}$, $0 \leq t \leq 1$, with the corresponding family of nested open sets Ω_t^i, such that

$$\mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma_t^i) \leq \max\left\{\mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma_{t_i}), \mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma_{t_{i+1}})\right\} + \varepsilon.$$

Assume (2.1) - (2.4) holds for all Ω_0^j and Ω_1^j for $j < i$. To define Ω_0^i and Ω_1^i, we only need to consider the following two cases:

- **Case (A) of Lemma 1.5.2 (1.3):**
  In this case, $\Omega_{t_i} \subset \Omega_{t_{i+1}}$. We take $\Omega_0^i = \Omega_{t_i}$ and $\Omega_1^i = \Omega_{t_{i+1}}$ so that (2.1)-(2.3) would be automatically satisfied. (2.4) would follow from case (A) of Lemma 1.5.2 (1.3).

- **Case (B) of Lemma 1.5.2 (1.3):**
  In this case, $\Omega_{t_{i+1}} \subset \Omega_{t_i}$. We define $\Omega_1^i = \Omega_{t_{i+1}}$ and

$$\Omega_0^i = \Omega_{t_{i+1}} \setminus \mathrm{cl}(N_\delta(\partial \Omega_{t_{i+1}}))$$

for sufficiently small $\delta > 0$ so that $N_\delta(\partial\Omega_{t_{i+1}})$ is diffeomorphic to $\partial\Omega_{t_{i+1}} \times [-\delta, \delta]$ and hypersurfaces equidistant from $\partial\Omega_{t_{i+1}}$ in this neighbourhood and for each $s \in [-\delta, \delta]$, we have

$$\mathcal{H}^n(\partial\Omega_{t_{i+1}} \times \{s\}) \leq \mathbf{M}(\partial_I \Omega_{t_{i+1}}) + \varepsilon/2.$$

Thus, $\Omega_0^i \subset \Omega_{t_i}$ and we will set $\Omega_1^i = \Omega_{t_{i+1}}$.

Consider Ω_0^{i+1}. In case (A), it is defined as $\Omega_{t_{i+1}}$ thus

$$\Omega_0^{i+1} = \Omega_{t_{i+1}} = \Omega_1^i$$

In case (B), it is defined as

$$\Omega_0^{i+1} \subset \Omega_{t_{i+2}} \subset \Omega_{t_{i+1}} = \Omega_1^i.$$

Therefore, we can conclude that

(2.5) $\Omega_0^{i+1} \subset \Omega_1^i$.

Roughly speaking, the reason why (2.5) holds is because to construct Ω_0^{i+1} we push $\Omega_{t_{i+1}}$ inward (or not at all) and to construct Ω_1^i we push $\Omega_{t_{i+1}}$ outwards (or not at all).

Step 3: Gluing Nested Families

The final step is to glue together the nested families constructed on each interval $[t_i, t_{i+1}]$ into a single global nested sweepout of U. The key observation from Step 2 is that adjacent intervals satisfy the compatibility condition $\Omega_0^{i+1} \subset \Omega_1^i$, which allows us to apply the gluing proposition below repeatedly.

In this section, we prove the following:

Proposition 1.5.3. *Suppose $\{\Gamma_t^a\}$ and $\{\Gamma_t^b\}$ are two nested families (with corresponding families of open sets $\{\Omega_t^a\}$ and $\{\Omega_t^b\}$ respectively) and $\mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma_t^i) \leq W$.*

Suppose moreover that $\Omega_0^b \subset \Omega_1^a$. For any $\varepsilon > 0$ there exists a nested family $\{\Gamma_t\}$ and a corresponding family of open sets $\{\Omega_t\}$ such that

$$\mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma_t) \leq W + \varepsilon,$$

$\Omega_1^b \subset \Omega_1$ *and* $\Omega_0 \subset \Omega_0^a$.

Proof. Let $\mathcal{S}$ denote the collection of all open sets Ω' such that $\Omega_0^b \subset \Omega' \subset \Omega_1^a$ and $\partial\Omega'$ is smooth. Let

$$A = \inf_{\Omega' \in \mathcal{S}} \mathbf{M}(\partial_I \Omega')$$

and choose $\Omega \in \mathcal{S}$ with

$$\mathbf{M}(\partial_I \Omega) < A + \frac{\varepsilon}{4}.$$

We set $\alpha = \partial\Omega$. We claim that Ω and α satisfy properties (1) and (2) from Lemma 1.4.1I for $\Omega_t = \Omega_t^a$. Indeed if Ω' satisfies $\Omega \subset \Omega' \subset \Omega_1$, we have

$$\begin{aligned}\mathcal{H}^n(\alpha) <& A + \frac{\varepsilon}{4} \\ \leq& \mathbf{M}(\partial_I \Omega') + \frac{\varepsilon}{4}\end{aligned}$$

Thus, we know that there exists a nested family $\{\tilde{\Gamma}_t^a\}$ with the corresponding family of open sets $\{\tilde{\Omega}_t^a\}$, such that $\tilde{\Omega}_0^a \subset \Omega_0^a$, $\tilde{\Gamma}_1^a = \alpha$ and

$$\mathcal{H}^n(\tilde{\Gamma}_t^a) \leq W + \varepsilon.$$

On the other hand, Ω and α also satisfy properties $(1)'$ and $(2)'$ from Lemma 1.4.1II for $\Omega_t = \Omega_t^b$. Indeed, for any open set Ω' with $\Omega_0^b \subset \Omega' \subset \Omega$ then again we have $\Omega_0^b \subset \Omega$ and

$$\mathcal{H}^n(\alpha) < \mathbf{M}(\partial_I \Omega') + \frac{\varepsilon}{4}$$

Therefore, there exists a nested family $\{\tilde{\Gamma}_t^b\}$ with the corresponding family of open sets $\{\tilde{\Omega}_t^b\}$, such that $\Omega_1^b \subset \tilde{\Omega}_1^b$, $\tilde{\Gamma}_0^b = \alpha$ and

$$\mathcal{H}^n(\tilde{\Gamma}_t^b) \leq W + \varepsilon.$$

We define the desired nested family Γ_t simply by concatenating these two nested families. □

Now we complete the proof of Proposition 1.5.1. We apply local monotonization 1.5 to define families $\{\Gamma_t^i\}$ for $i = 1, \ldots, N-1$.

By (2.5), we have

$$\Omega_0^2 \subset \Omega_1^1$$

Hence, we can apply Proposition 1.5.3 to the nested family $\{\Gamma_t^1\}$ and $\{\Gamma_t^2\}$. We obtain a new nested family $\left\{\Gamma_t^{1,2}\right\}$ with the corresponding family of open sets $\left\{\Omega_t^{1,2}\right\}$. Moreover, by (2.5) and Proposition 1.5.3, we have

$$\Omega_0^{1,2} \subset \Omega_0^1 \subset \Omega_0 \quad \text{and} \quad \Omega_1 \subset \Omega_1^2 \subset \Omega_1^{1,2}$$

Using (2.5) again, we have

$$\Omega_0^3 \subset \Omega_1^2 \subset \Omega_1^{1,2}$$

Hence, we can apply Proposition 1.5.3 to the nested family $\{\Gamma_t^3\}$ and $\left\{\Gamma_t^{1,2}\right\}$. We obtain a new nested family $\left\{\Gamma_t^{1,2,3}\right\}$ with the corresponding family of open sets $\left\{\Omega_t^{1,2,3}\right\}$.

We iterate this procedure inductively. At the i-th step, we can apply the Proposition 1.5.3 to families $\left\{\Gamma_t^{1,\ldots,i}\right\}$ and $\left\{\Gamma_t^{i+1}\right\}$ to construct a new nested family $\left\{\Gamma_t^{1,\ldots,i,i+1}\right\}$ with $\Omega_0^{1,\ldots,i}$ and $\{\Omega_1\} \subset \Omega_1^{1,\ldots,i}$, which would again guarantee that $\Omega_0^{i+2} \subset \Omega_1^{1,\ldots,i}$, so that we can go to the next step.

After iteratively performing this operation N times we obtain the desired nested family. This finishes the proof of Proposition 1.5.1.

1.6 NO ESCAPE TO INFINITY

A key difficulty in min–max theory on *complete* manifolds (with or without boundary) is ensuring that the min–max sequence does not "escape to infinity"—that is, that slices with large area do not concentrate all their mass arbitrarily far from the good set U. As observed in [CL20], this is fundamentally a problem caused by the *completeness* of the manifold: in a compact manifold, such escape is topologically impossible, but in a complete non-compact setting, one must prove that the min–max construction forces slices to remain localized near U.

This section establishes a quantitative non-escape result: any good sweepout must have at least one slice carrying a definite amount of area inside U. The free-boundary setting introduces additional technical complications in the proof (particularly in handling boundary collars and relative isoperimetric estimates), but the fundamental difficulty remains the completeness of the ambient manifold.

The proof proceeds by contradiction: assuming every slice with large area has negligible intersection with $\overline{U}$, we use the nested sweepout structure from Section 1.5 to construct a competing sweepout with strictly smaller width, contradicting the definition of $W_g(U)$. The precise statement is:

Proposition 1.6.1. *For every good set U, there exists a positive constant $\varepsilon(U)$ which depends only on U such that the following holds: For every good sweepout $\{\Gamma_t\}$ of U with associated family of open sets $\{\Omega_t\}$, there exists $t' \in [0,1]$ such that*

$$\mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma_{t'}) \geq W_g(U),$$

and such that $\mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma_{t'} \cap cl(U)) \geq \varepsilon(U)$.

The proof is by contradiction. We assume that Proposition 1.6.1 does not hold, i.e. we can construct a good sweepout with volume of hypersurfaces

strictly less than $W_g(U)$. The main tool in the proof is the structure of the nested sweepout from Proposition 1.5.1.

The first technical ingredient is a lemma that allows us to deform a set with small intersection with U so that it avoids U entirely, while controlling the area increase. Let U be a good set.

Lemma 1.6.2. *There exist $\varepsilon(U) > 0$, $\varepsilon_0(U) > 0$ and $\varepsilon_1(U) > 0$ such that for any open sets Ω' the following holds:*

1. $\max\{\varepsilon, \varepsilon_1\} < \mathbf{M}(\partial_I U)/10$;
2. *If $\varepsilon_0 < \mathcal{H}^{n+1}(\Omega' \cap U) < \mathcal{H}^{n+1}(U) - \varepsilon_0$, then $\mathbf{M}(\partial_I \Omega' \cap U) > 2\varepsilon$;*
3. (A) *If $\mathcal{H}^{n+1}(\Omega' \cap U) < 2\varepsilon_0$, then there exists a family of open sets $\{\Xi_t\}$ with*

$$\begin{aligned}
&\Xi_0 = \Omega';\\
&\Xi_t \backslash N_{\varepsilon_1}(U) = \Omega' \backslash N_{\varepsilon_1}(U);\\
&\Xi_1 \cap U = \varnothing\\
&\mathbf{M}(\partial_I \Xi_t) < \mathbf{M}(\partial_I \Omega') + \mathbf{M}(\partial_I U) + \varepsilon_1.
\end{aligned}$$

   (B) *If $\mathcal{H}^{n+1}(\Omega' \cap U) > \mathcal{H}^{n+1}(U) - 2\varepsilon_0$, then there exists a family of open sets $\{\Xi_t\}$ with*

$$\begin{aligned}
&\Xi_0 = \Omega';\\
&\Xi_t \backslash N_{\varepsilon_1}(U) = \Omega' \backslash N_{\varepsilon_1}(U);\\
&\Xi_1 \cap U = U\\
&\mathbf{M}(\partial_I \Xi_t) < \mathbf{M}(\partial_I \Omega') + \mathbf{M}(\partial_I U) + \varepsilon_1.
\end{aligned}$$

Proof. Pick some $\varepsilon_1 \in (0, \mathcal{H}^n(\partial_I U)/10)$.

We will show that for all sufficiently small ε_0 (with the choice of ε_0 depending on ε_1) statement (3) holds;

We will show that for all sufficiently small ε (with the choice of ε depending on ε_0) statement (2) holds; the argument relies on the convexity properties of the isoperimetric profile of $\overline{U}$.

We will prove Statement(3)(A). And the statement (3)(B) would be similar.

Let $r_0 > 0$ be sufficiently small, so that every ball B of radius $r \in (0, r_0]$ centered at a point in $cl(U)$ is 2-biLipschitz diffeomorphic to a ball of the same radius in the Euclidean space.

Choose a covering $\{B_i\}$ of $cl(U)$ by N balls of radius r_0, so that concentric balls of radius $\frac{r_0}{2}$, denoted by $\frac{1}{2}B_i$, still cover $cl(U)$. Set

$$\varepsilon_0 := \min\left\{\frac{\varepsilon_1 r_0}{20N}, \left(\frac{\varepsilon_1}{2^{n+2}C(n)N}\right)^{\frac{n+1}{n}}\right\}, \tag{1.5}$$

where $C(n)$ is the constant from Lemma 1.3.3. Using the coarea inequality (Lemma 1.2.8), we may choose a covering $\{B_i'\}$ of U by N balls of radius $r_i \in (r_0/2, r_0)$, so that

$$\mathcal{H}^n((\partial B_i') \cap (\Omega' \cap U)) \leq \frac{4\varepsilon_0}{r_0} \leq \frac{\varepsilon_1}{5N}. \tag{1.6}$$

Note that the second inequality follows from the first term in the definition of ε_0 in (1.5): since $\varepsilon_0 \leq \frac{\varepsilon_1 r_0}{20N}$, we have $\frac{4\varepsilon_0}{r_0} \leq \frac{4\varepsilon_1 r_0}{20Nr_0} = \frac{\varepsilon_1}{5N}$.

We are going to inductively push Ω' outside of $B_1' \cap U, B_2' \cap U, \ldots, B_N' \cap U$:

We can start with pushing Ω' outside of $B_1' \cap U$ as in Figure 1.5. By Lemma 1.3.3, for any $\varepsilon > 0$ sufficiently small (smaller than $\frac{\varepsilon_1}{20N}$ in fact), we can construct a nested family $\{\Xi_t^1\}$ that starts on Ω' and ends on a

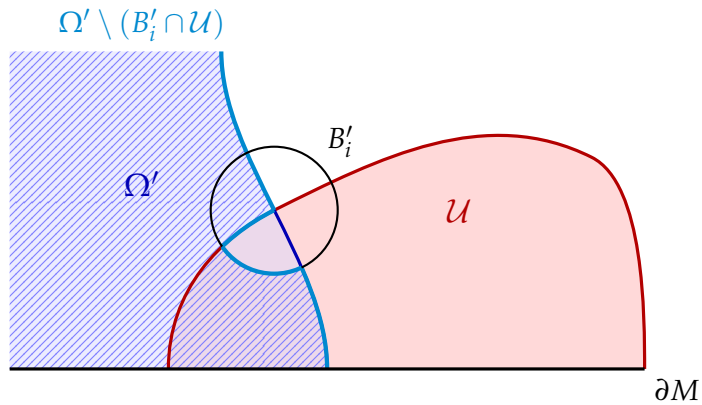

Figure 1.5: Pushing Ω' outside of $B_1' \cap U$. The region Ω' (blue) overlaps with $\mathcal{U}$ (red) near the ball B_i'. The set $\Omega' \setminus (B_i' \cap \mathcal{U})$ is obtained by removing the portion of Ω' inside $B_i' \cap \mathcal{U}$.

smoothing of $\Omega' \setminus (B_1' \cap U)$. We can choose the smoothing so that the set does not intersect $B_1' \cap U$. And in this step,

$$\begin{aligned}
\mathbf{M}(\partial_I \Xi_t^1) \leq & \mathbf{M}(\partial_I \Omega') + \mathbf{M}(\partial_I (B_1' \cap U \cap \Omega')) \\
& + 2^n C(n) \mathcal{H}^{n+1}(B_1' \cap U \cap \Omega') + \varepsilon \\
\leq & \mathbf{M}(\partial_I \Omega') + \mathcal{H}^n(B_1' \cap \partial_I U) + \mathcal{H}^n((\partial B_1') \cap (\Omega' \cap U)) \\
& + 2^n C(n) \varepsilon_0^{\frac{n}{n+1}} + \varepsilon \quad \text{By 1.5} \\
\leq & \mathbf{M}(\partial_I \Omega') + \mathcal{H}^n(B_1' \cap \partial_I U) + \frac{\varepsilon_1}{5N} + \frac{\varepsilon_1}{4N} + \varepsilon \quad \text{by 1.6} \\
\leq & \mathbf{M}(\partial_I \Omega') + \mathcal{H}^n(B_1' \cap \partial_I U) + \frac{\varepsilon_1}{2N}
\end{aligned}$$

We can iterate this procedure for each ball B_i'. During the i-th step, $1 \leq i \leq N$, we have that

$$\mathbf{M}(\partial_I \Xi_t^i) \leq \mathbf{M}(\partial_I \Omega') + \mathcal{H}^n(\partial_I U) + \frac{i\varepsilon_1}{2N}$$

That means we can conclude (3)(A) after gluing these together via Proposition 1.5.3. □

We are now ready to prove Proposition 1.6.1 by contradiction. Suppose there exists a good sweepout $\{\Gamma_t\}_{t\in[0,1]}$ such that whenever

$$\mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma_t) \geq W_g(U)$$

we have $\mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma_t \cap U) < \varepsilon(U)$. Our goal is to construct a good sweepout entirely inside U whose maximal slice area is *strictly less* than $W_g(U)$, contradicting the definition of $W_g(U)$ as the infimum of maximal areas over all good sweepouts of U.

Let $f(t) = \mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma_t \cap U)$. Note that $f(t)$ may not be continuous. However, it is easy to see that one can perturb the family $\{\Gamma_t\}$ so that it is δ-continuous in the following sense.

Definition 1.6.3. Function $f(t)$ is **δ-continuous** if the oscillation

$$\omega_f(t) := \lim_{a\to 0}[\sup_{s\in[t-a,t+a]} f(s) - \inf_{s\in[t-a,t+a]} f(s)]$$

satisfies $\omega_f(t) < \delta$ for every t.

Lemma 1.6.4 (δ-continuous perturbation)**.** *Let U be a bounded relative open subset to M with smooth relative boundary and $\{\Gamma_t\}$ be a good sweepout of U. For every $\delta > 0$ there exists a good sweepout $\{\Gamma'_t\}$ of U, such that*

- *$f(t) = \mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma'_t \cap U)$ is δ-continuous;*
- *$\sup_t \mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma'_t) \leq \sup_t \mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma_t) + \delta$;*
- *$\sup_t \mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma'_t \cap U) \leq \sup_t \mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma_t \cap U) + \delta$.*

Proof. Fix $\delta > 0$ and set $\varepsilon := \delta/6$. By Lemma 1.5.2 with parameter ε, from $\{\Gamma_t\}$ we obtain a piecewise nested family $\{\widetilde{\Gamma}_t\}$ and a partition $0 = t_0 < \cdots < t_N = 1$ such that

$$\sup_t \mathcal{H}^n(\widetilde{\Gamma}_t) \leq \sup_t \mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma_t) + \varepsilon,$$
$$\sup_t \mathcal{H}^n(\widetilde{\Gamma}_t \cap U) \leq \sup_t \mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma_t \cap U) + \varepsilon.$$

Indeed, the preliminary modification acts only inside finitely many thin annuli and endpoint collars; by (iii)–(iv) of Lemma 1.5.2 the M–area increase is $\leq \varepsilon$, and restricting to U with the coarea inequality (Lemma 1.2.8) yields the same ε–bound for the U–area.

For each subinterval $[t_i, t_{i+1}]$ given by the preliminary modification, we may represent $\left\{\widetilde{\Gamma}_t\right\}_{t\in[t_i,t_{i+1}]}$ as level sets of an admissible Morse function. Let $\mathcal{S}$ denote the finite set consisting of the partition points $\{t_1, \ldots, t_{N-1}\}$ together with all critical values of these Morse functions. Choose $\eta > 0$ so small that the open intervals

$$J_s := (s - \eta, s + \eta) \subset (0, 1), \qquad s \in \mathcal{S}$$

are pairwise disjoint. We keep the family unchanged outside the buffers and set

$$\Gamma'_t := \widetilde{\Gamma}_t \qquad \text{for all } t \notin \bigcup_{s\in\mathcal{S}} J_s.$$

All subsequent modifications will be supported inside the union of the buffers $\bigcup_{s\in\mathcal{S}} J_s$.

Fix $s \in \mathcal{S}$ and set

$$\Omega^- := \widetilde{\Omega}_{s-\eta} \subset \Omega^+ := \widetilde{\Omega}_{s+\eta}, \qquad D_s := \Omega^+ \setminus \Omega^-.$$

Shrinking $\eta > 0$ if necessary and using the coarea inequality (Lemma 1.2.8) and the small-volume choice from Lemma 1.5.2, we may assume

$$\mathcal{H}^n(\partial D_s \cap U) + (\mathcal{H}^{n+1}(D_s))^{\frac{n}{n+1}} < \varepsilon_s,$$

with $\sum_{s\in\mathcal{S}} \varepsilon_s \leq \varepsilon$. Cover $\overline{D_s}$ by the bilipschitz balls used in the preliminary modification (interior balls mapped to balls in $\mathbb{R}^{n+1}$; boundary balls, via a fixed collar, to half-balls in $\mathbb{R}^{n+1}_+$, with vector fields tangent to ∂M).

Applying Lemma 1.4.3 and gluing, we obtain a nested family $\{\Gamma'_t\}_{t\in J_s}$ connecting $\partial\Omega^-$ to $\partial\Omega^+$ such that, for all $t \in J_s$,

$$\begin{aligned}\mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma'_t) \leq& \mathbf{M}(\partial_I\Omega^-) + \mathbf{M}(\partial_I D_s)\\ &+ C(n)(1+L_{\text{ball}})^n\big(\mathcal{H}^{n+1}(D_s)\big)^{\frac{n}{n+1}} + \varepsilon_s,\\ \mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma'_t \cap U) \leq& \mathcal{H}^n(\partial\Omega^- \cap U) + \mathcal{H}^n(\partial D_s \cap U)\\ &+ C(n)(1+L_{\text{ball}})^n\big(\mathcal{H}^{n+1}(D_s)\big)^{\frac{n}{n+1}} + \varepsilon_s,\end{aligned}$$

where $L_{\text{ball}} := (1+\frac{\varepsilon}{100W})^{1/n} - 1$ so that $(1+L_{\text{ball}})^n \leq 1 + \frac{\varepsilon}{100W}$.

By shrinking $\eta > 0$ if necessary, choose numbers $\{\varepsilon_s\}_{s\in\mathcal{S}}$ so that the estimates in the previous paragraph hold and

$$\sum_{s\in\mathcal{S}} \varepsilon_s \leq \varepsilon.$$

Define the final family by

$$\Gamma'_t := \begin{cases} \widetilde{\Gamma}_t, & t \notin \bigcup_{s\in\mathcal{S}} J_s,\\ \text{the bridged slice constructed on } J_s, & t \in J_s \text{ for some } s \in \mathcal{S}.\end{cases}$$

Using the sup–bounds from the preliminary modification and the bridge estimates on each J_s, we obtain

$$\begin{aligned}\sup_t \mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma'_t) &\leq \sup_t \mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma_t) + \varepsilon + \sum_{s\in\mathcal{S}} \varepsilon_s \leq \sup_t \mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma_t) + 2\varepsilon,\\ \sup_t \mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma'_t \cap U) &\leq \sup_t \mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma_t \cap U) + \varepsilon + \sum_{s\in\mathcal{S}} \varepsilon_s \leq \sup_t \mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma_t \cap U) + 2\varepsilon.\end{aligned}$$

(Any endpoint adjustment inside a fixed collar of ∂U preserves the "good" endpoints and adds at most ε to the above sup–bounds.) □

Let $g : [0,1] \to [0, \mathcal{H}^{n+1}(U)]$ be defined by

$$g(t) := \mathcal{H}^{n+1}(U \cap \Omega_t),$$

which is continuous. By Lemma 1.6.2 (2), if I' is a connected component of $g^{-1}([\varepsilon_0,\ \mathcal{H}^{n+1}(U)-\varepsilon_0])$, then for every $t \in I'$ we have

$$f(t) := \mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma_t \cap U) \geq 2\varepsilon.$$

Applying Lemma 1.6.4 with $\delta < \varepsilon/10$ we obtain a good sweepout $\{\Gamma'_t\}$ such that $f'(t) := \mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma'_t \cap U)$ is δ-continuous. By continuity of g and the sweepout property, there exists a closed interval $I = [t_0, t_1]$ with $I' \subset I \subset [0,1]$ such that

$$g(t_0) \leq \varepsilon_0, \qquad g(t_1) \geq \mathcal{H}^{n+1}(U) - \varepsilon_0, \tag{1.7}$$

and (possibly shrinking I slightly) we have for all $t \in I$

$$f'(t) \geq \frac{3}{2}\varepsilon.$$

Moreover, by the choice of endpoints and the δ–continuity (with $\delta < \varepsilon/10$) together with the contrapositive of Lemma 1.6.2 (2), we may assume

$$\varepsilon \leq f'(t_i) \leq 2\varepsilon, \qquad i = 0, 1.$$

For the upper bound, note that the contrapositive of Lemma 1.6.2 (2) says: if $f'(t_i) > 2\varepsilon$ then

$$g(t_i) \in \big(\varepsilon_0,\ \mathcal{H}^{n+1}(U) - \varepsilon_0\big),$$

which contradicts our choice of the endpoints (see (1.7) for the bounds on $g(t_i)$).

For the lower bound, since f' is δ-continuous with $\delta < \varepsilon/10$ and on the interior interval we have $f' \geq \frac{3}{2}\varepsilon$, choosing t_i sufficiently close to the boundary of I' yields

$$f'(t_i) \geq \tfrac{3}{2}\varepsilon - \delta > \varepsilon.$$

Remark 1.6.5 (Why enlarge I' to a closed interval I). Enlarging a connected component $I' \subset B$ to $I = [t_0, t_1]$ with $g(t_0) \leq \varepsilon_0$ and $g(t_1) \geq \mathcal{H}^{n+1}(U) - \varepsilon_0$

is essential: (i) it yields a thin error set P (hence the inward perturbation $\overline{U}$ with controlled relative boundary); (ii) by δ–continuity it provides endpoint anchors $\varepsilon \leq f(t_i) \leq 2\varepsilon$ needed for the cut–cap–insert step; (iii) on the compact interval I we obtain a strict gap $\sup_{t\in I} \mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma_t) < W_g(U)$, which survives the nested replacement and underwrites the final contradiction.

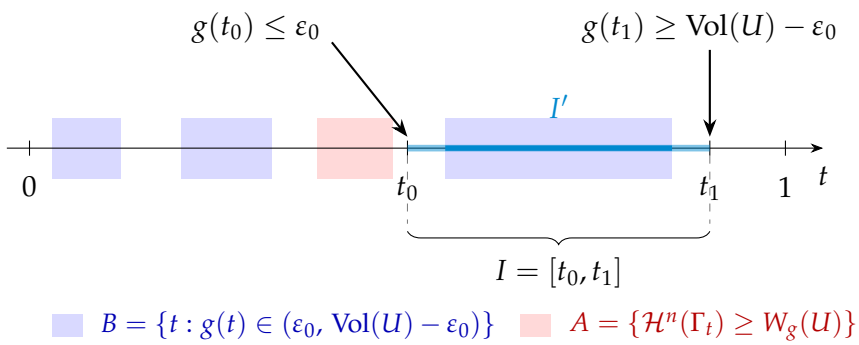

Figure 1.6: Time–axis schematic. The blue bands show $B = \{t : g(t) \in (\varepsilon_0, \mathrm{Vol}(U) - \varepsilon_0)\}$; the red band shows $A = \{t : \mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma_t \cap M) \geq W_g(U)\}$ with $A \cap B = \varnothing$. A connected component $I' \subset B$ is enlarged to $I = [t_0, t_1]$ with $g(t_0) \leq \varepsilon_0$, $g(t_1) \geq \mathrm{Vol}(U) - \varepsilon_0$.

Relabelling f' back to f and Γ'_t back to Γ_t, define

$$A := \left\{t \in [0,1] : \ \mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma_t) \geq W_g(U)\right\},$$
$$B := \left\{t \in [0,1] : \ g(t) \in (\varepsilon_0, \ \mathcal{H}^{n+1}(U) - \varepsilon_0)\right\}.$$

By Lemma 1.6.2 (2), $t \in B \Rightarrow f(t) \geq 2\varepsilon$, hence $A \cap B = \emptyset$. Since $I \subset B$, we have

$$\mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma_t) \ < \ W_g(U) \qquad \text{for all } t \in I.$$

By piecewise continuity of $t \mapsto \mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma_t)$ on the compact interval I, there exists

$$m := \sup_{t\in I} \mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma_t) < W_g(U), \qquad \delta_1 := W_g(U) - m > 0.$$

Apply the nested–replacement proposition from Section 6 (Proposition 1.5.1) to $\{\Gamma_t\}_{t\in I}$. We obtain a nested family $\{\overline{\Gamma}_t\}_{t\in[0,1]}$ with associated open sets $\{\overline{\Omega}_t\}$ such that

$$\sup_{t\in[0,1]} \mathcal{H}^n(\overline{\Gamma}_t) \;\le\; m - \tfrac{\delta_1}{2} \;<\; W_g(U) - \tfrac{\delta_1}{2},$$

and

$$\overline{\Omega}_0 \subset \Omega_{t_0}, \qquad \Omega_{t_1} \subset \overline{\Omega}_1.$$

Define the thin error set

$$P \;:=\; (\Omega_{t_0} \cap U) \;\cup\; \big(U \setminus \mathrm{cl}(\Omega_{t_1})\big).$$

By the endpoint volume bounds $g(t_0) \le \varepsilon_0$ and $g(t_1) \ge \mathcal{H}^{n+1}(U) - \varepsilon_0$, both $\Omega_{t_0} \cap U$ and $U \setminus \mathrm{cl}(\Omega_{t_1})$ have measure $\le \varepsilon_0$, hence $\mathcal{H}^{n+1}(P) \le 2\varepsilon_0$. Remove P from U and smooth inward inside a fixed collar of ∂U to obtain a slightly shrunken open set $\overline{U} \subset U$ (an relative inward δ-perturbation of $U \setminus \mathrm{cl}(P)$). Then, as in [CL20, p. 26], we may assume:

(i) $\{\overline{\Gamma}_t\}$ *restricts to a nested sweepout of* $\overline{U}$. Since $\overline{\Omega}_0 \subset \Omega_{t_0}$ and $\Omega_{t_1} \subset \overline{\Omega}_1$, removing the very thin set P does not break nestedness; reparametrising the family and performing corner-smoothing inside the collar of ∂U yields a nested sweepout of $\overline{U}$.

(ii) *Relative boundary control:*

$$\mathbf{M}(\partial_I \overline{U}) \;\le\; \mathbf{M}(\partial_I U) \;+\; C\,\varepsilon_0^{\frac{n}{n+1}} \;\le\; 2\,\mathbf{M}(\partial_I U)$$

for $\varepsilon_0 = \varepsilon_0(U)$ chosen sufficiently small. Here the extra term comes from the new boundary created by excising P and the inward smoothing; it is controlled by the relative isoperimetric/coarea inequalities applied to $\mathcal{H}^{n+1}(P) \le 2\varepsilon_0$.

(iii) *Push-out with controlled area:* there exists a homotopy supported in the collar of ∂U, generated by vector fields tangent to ∂M, that pushes $\partial_I \overline{U}$ outside U through slices of area at most $3\mathbf{M}(\partial_I U)$, after absorbing the $O(\varepsilon_0^{\frac{n}{n+1}})$ error into the constant (again by choosing $\varepsilon_0(U)$ small). This is the relative version of the short "push across the collar" used in [CL20].

Before proceeding, we isolate a slice of the nested family whose portion *outside* the shrunken set $\overline{U}$ is uniformly controlled. This is the key bridge between the global width bound and a sweepout confined to $\overline{U}$: once such a slice is found, we can (i) cut the family at that time, (ii) cap the outside part by using only boundary data of U, and (iii) build a sweepout of $\overline{U}$ whose maximal area is strictly below $W_g(U)$. The next lemma provides precisely this slice-level estimate and makes the subsequent "cut–and–insert" step possible.

Lemma 1.6.6 (relative version of Lemma 7.4 in [CL20])**.** *There exists $t_0 \in [0,1]$ such that*

$$\mathcal{H}^n(\overline{\Gamma}_{t_0} \setminus \overline{U}) \leq 2\mathbf{M}(\partial_I U).$$

Proof. Let $L := \sup_{t\in[0,1]} \mathcal{H}^n(\overline{\Gamma}_t \cap \overline{U})$. By the Morse–foliation construction on $\overline{U}$ and the relative boundary control in (ii), we can sweep out $\overline{U}$ by slices of area at most

$$L + \mathbf{M}(\partial_I \overline{U}) + \delta \leq L + 2\,\mathbf{M}(\partial_I U) + \delta.$$

Using (iii), we extend this to a good sweepout of U (the homotopy is supported in a fixed collar of ∂U and generated by vector fields tangent to ∂M) whose maximal slice area is at most $L + 2\,\mathbf{M}(\partial_I U) + \delta$. Hence, by the definition of $W_g(U)$,

$$W_g(U) \leq L + 2\mathbf{M}(\partial_I U) + \delta.$$

If, for every $t \in [0,1]$, we had $\mathcal{H}^n(\overline{\Gamma}_t \setminus \overline{U}) \ > \ 2\,\mathbf{M}(\partial_I U)$, then

$$\begin{aligned}\mathcal{H}^n(\overline{\Gamma}_t) &= \mathcal{H}^n(\overline{\Gamma}_t \cap \overline{U}) + \mathcal{H}^n((\overline{\Gamma}_t \cap M) \setminus \overline{U}) \\ &> L + 2\mathbf{M}(\partial_I U) \\ &\geq W_g(U) - \delta\end{aligned}$$

contradicting $\sup_t \mathcal{H}^n(\overline{\Gamma}_t) \leq W_g(U) - \delta_1/2$ for $\delta > 0$ chosen smaller than $\delta_1/2$. Therefore such t_0 exists. □

Let

$$\begin{aligned}\mathcal{U}_0 &:= \left\{\Omega : \overline{\Omega}_0 \subset \Omega \subset \overline{\Omega}_{t_0} \setminus \overline{U}\right\}; \\ \mathcal{U}_1 &:= \left\{\Omega : \overline{\Omega}_{t_0} \cup \overline{U} \subset \Omega \subset \overline{\Omega}_1\right\}\end{aligned}$$

and define

$$A_i := \inf\left\{\mathbf{M}(\partial_I \Omega) : \Omega \in \mathcal{U}_i\right\}, \qquad i = 0, 1.$$

By Lemma 1.6.6 and property (ii) for $\overline{U}$, we have

$$A_i \ \leq \ 3\,\mathbf{M}(\partial_I U).$$

Choose $\Sigma_i = \partial \Xi_i$ with $\Xi_i \in \mathcal{U}_i$ such that

$$\mathcal{H}^n(\Sigma_i) \ \leq \ A_i + \delta/4.$$

Applying the relative nested–insertion lemmas (Lemma 1.4.1(I),(II) in our Section 5) *inside* $\overline{U}$ and concatenating, we obtain a nested sweepout of $\overline{U}$ from Σ_0 to Σ_1 whose maximal slice area (measured in M) satisfies

$$\sup_t \ \mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma_t^{\overline{U}}) \ \leq \ W_g(U) - \delta/4.$$

Using Lemma 1.6.2 (3) (relative push across a ∂U–collar), we upgrade this to a good sweepout of U with

$$\sup_t \mathcal{H}^n(\Gamma_t^U) \leq W_g(U) - \delta/4,$$

contradicting the definition of $W_g(U)$. This completes the proof of Proposition 1.6.1.

1.7 CONVERGENCE OF THE MIN–MAX SEQUENCE

This section completes the proof of the main theorem. Starting from the good sweepouts constructed in the preceding sections, we perform a pull–tight deformation on an exhaustion of M, extract a varifold limit that is almost minimizing in small annuli, and apply the regularity theory of Li–Zhou [LZ21] to obtain a smooth, almost properly embedded free boundary minimal hypersurface.

Throughout this section, "stationary" means stationary in M with free boundary (Definition 1.2.11).

Pull–tight on a non-compact manifold

Fix a good set $U \subset M$. By Proposition 1.5.1, there exist good sweepouts of U with maximal area arbitrarily close to $W_g(U)$. Since M is non-compact, we cannot pull tight on all of M at once. Following Chambers–Liokumovich [CL20, §7], we pull tight layer by layer on a bounded exhaustion and combine the results via a diagonal argument.

Let $U_0 \Subset U_1 \Subset \cdots \Subset M$ be bounded relative open sets with $M = \bigcup_i U_i$ and $U \Subset U_0$. Since each $\overline{U_i}$ is compact, the monotonicity formula [LZ21,

Theorem 2.1] and Li–Zhou's estimates [LZ21, Section 3] apply on each U_i. For each i, choose W_i with $U_i \Subset W_i \Subset U_{i+1}$. Set $C := 2W_g(U)$ and define

$$\mathcal{V}^C(\Omega) := \big\{V \in \mathcal{V}_n(M) : \operatorname{spt}\|V\| \subset \overline{\Omega},\ \|V\|(M) \le C\big\},$$

$$\mathcal{V}^C_\infty(\Omega) := \big\{V \in \mathcal{V}^C(\Omega) : V \text{ is stationary in } \Omega \text{ with free boundary}\big\}.$$

Both sets are compact under the varifold metric $\mathbf{F}$ when Ω is bounded (see [LZ21, Lemma 3.4]). For the full (non-compact) manifold, we define analogously

$$\mathcal{V}^C(M) := \big\{V \in \mathcal{V}_n(M) : \|V\|(M) \le C\big\},$$

$$\mathcal{V}^C_\infty(M) := \big\{V \in \mathcal{V}^C(M) : V \text{ is stationary in } M \text{ with free boundary}\big\}.$$

Note that $\mathcal{V}^C(U_j) \subset \mathcal{V}^C(M)$ for every j, but $\mathcal{V}^C(M)$ itself is *not* compact under $\mathbf{F}$ when M is non-compact, since a sequence of varifolds whose supports escape to infinity need not have an $\mathbf{F}$-convergent subsequence.

Lemma 1.7.1 (Pull–tight map [CL20, Lemma 2.3])**.** *For every i there exist a continuous map $\Phi_{U_i,W_i} : \mathcal{V}^C(M) \to \mathcal{V}^C(M)$ with the following properties for all $V \in \mathcal{V}^C(M)$:*

1. (Mass non-increase) $\|\Phi_{U_i,W_i}(V)\|(M) \le \|V\|(M)$;
2. (Inactivity below threshold) *If* $\|V\|(\overline{W}_i) \le 5\,\mathbf{M}(\partial_I U)$, *then* $\Phi_{U_i,W_i}(V) = V$;
3. (Strict decrease for non-stationary varifolds) *If* $\|V\|(\overline{W}_i) \ge 9\,\mathbf{M}(\partial_I U)$ *and* $\mathbf{F}_{U_i}\big(V \llcorner \mathrm{Gr}_n(U_i),\ \mathcal{V}^C_\infty(U_i)\big) \in \big[2^{-(k+1)}, 2^{-k}\big]$ *for some* $k \in \mathbb{N}$, *then:*
   (a) $\|\Phi_{U_i,W_i}(V)\|(M) \le \|V\|(M) - \varepsilon_k(U_i)$;
   (b) $\mathbf{F}\big(V,\ \Phi_{U_i,W_i}(V)\big) \le \tau_k(U_i)$;
   where $\varepsilon_k(U_i) \to 0$ *and* $\tau_k(U_i) \to 0$ *as* $k \to \infty$.

Proof. The construction follows [CL20, Lemma 2.3] verbatim, with the sole modification that all vector fields are taken in $\mathfrak{X}_{\tan}(M)$ (tangent to ∂M)

rather than $\mathfrak{X}_c(M)$. This does not affect the argument: the proof uses only that $\mathfrak{X}_{\tan}(M)$ is a closed subspace of $\mathfrak{X}_c(M)$ on which the covering, partition-of-unity, and flow constructions remain valid, and that non-stationarity with free boundary provides a vector field $X \in \mathfrak{X}_{\tan}(M)$ with $\delta V(X) < 0$. □

Remark 1.7.2 (Role of the thresholds). The constants $5\,\mathbf{M}(\partial_I U)$ and $9\,\mathbf{M}(\partial_I U)$ in Lemma 1.7.1 are not explained in [CL20] but play an important role. Endpoints of a good sweepout have mass at most $5\,\mathbf{M}(\partial_I U)$ (Definition 1.2.16), so property (2) leaves them unchanged. Moreover, since the flow is generated by vector fields supported in W_i with $U \Subset U_0 \Subset W_0$, it does not transport mass across $\partial_I U$. Together, these guarantee that the pull-tight preserves the good sweepout structure, so the non-escape property (Proposition 1.6.1) remains applicable. On the other hand, the min–max slices have mass close to $W_g(U) \geq \frac{9}{10} W_\partial(U) \gg 9\,\mathbf{M}(\partial_I U)$ (by the good set condition), so they are well above the threshold in property (3) and are actively pulled tight. The gap between 5 and 9 accommodates a continuous cutoff.

Let $\{\Gamma_t^i\}$ be a sequence of good sweepouts with $\sup_t \mathbf{M}(\Gamma_t^i) \downarrow W_g(U)$. On a compact manifold, one would apply a single pull-tight map to the entire sequence. Here M is non-compact, so instead we pull tight incrementally: the i-th sweepout is pulled tight on the first i layers of the exhaustion. Set

$$\mathbf{P}_i := \Phi_{U_0,W_0} \circ \Phi_{U_1,W_1} \circ \cdots \circ \Phi_{U_i,W_i}.$$

Thus $\mathbf{P}_i(\Gamma_t^i)$ has been pulled tight on $U_0, \ldots, U_i$: as $i \to \infty$ the number of layers grows with the exhaustion, so the limit varifold will be stationary on every U_j and hence on all of M.

Proposition 1.7.3 (Pulled–tight minimizing sequence)**.** *After passing to a subsequence, $\{\mathbf{P}_i(\Gamma_t^i)\}$ is a minimizing sequence of good sweepouts with*

$$\lim_{i\to\infty} \sup_{t\in[0,1]} \mathbf{M}\big(\mathbf{P}_i(\Gamma_t^i)\big) = W_g(U),$$

and any min–max sequence $\mathbf{P}_i(\Gamma_{t_i}^i)$ admits a subsequence converging to a varifold $V \in \mathcal{V}_\infty^C(M)$ that is stationary with free boundary.

Proof. The free boundary condition does not affect the argument: it relies only on the compactness of $\mathcal{V}^C(U_j)$ and on properties (1)–(3) of Lemma 1.7.1, all of which hold because the vector fields lie in $\mathfrak{X}_{\tan}(M)$. The proof follows [CL20, §7].

First, a contradiction argument using the mass decrease and **F**-displacement bounds in Lemma 1.7.1(3) shows that for every i,

$$\lim_{j\to\infty} \mathbf{F}_{U_i}\big(\mathbf{P}_j(\Gamma_{t_j}^j)\llcorner \mathrm{Gr}_n(U_i),\ \mathcal{V}_\infty^C(U_i)\big) = 0 : \tag{1.8}$$

if the $\mathbf{F}_{U_i}$-distance stayed bounded away from zero, then either some intermediate layer Φ_{U_l,W_l} would strictly decrease the mass by the ε_k-bound, or the τ_k-bound and the triangle inequality would force the final varifold close to $\mathcal{V}_\infty^C(U_i)$; in both cases one reaches a contradiction with $\mathbf{M}(\mathbf{P}_j(\Gamma_{t_j}^j)) \to W_g(U)$. See [CL20, §7] for the full details.

Next, a diagonal argument produces a subsequence converging in $\mathbf{F}_{U_j}$ for every j. Since $M = \bigcup_j U_j$, the limit varifold V is well-defined on all of M, and by (1.8) we have $V\llcorner \mathrm{Gr}_n(U_j) \in \mathcal{V}_\infty^C(U_j)$ for every j. It follows that V is stationary with free boundary on M: for any $X \in \mathfrak{X}_{\tan}(M)$, the support of X is contained in some U_j, and V is stationary on U_j, so $\delta V(X) = 0$. □

Almost minimizing varifolds with free boundary

The pulled-tight varifold V from Proposition 1.7.3 is stationary, but stationarity alone does not yield regularity. Following the Almgren–Pitts strategy, one needs the stronger *almost minimizing* property: roughly, V cannot be deformed to decrease its mass by much. In the closed (boundaryless) setting, this notion was introduced by Pitts [Pit81] and reformulated by De Lellis–Tasnady [DLT13]; the regularity of almost minimizing varifolds was established in [Pit81, DLT13]. Chambers–Liokumovich [CL20] use these results directly, as their manifolds have no boundary. For manifolds *with* boundary, Li–Zhou [LZ21, Sections 4–6] developed free boundary counterparts of both the almost minimizing definitions and the regularity theory, which are the versions we use here.

In this section we collect the relevant definitions and results from [LZ21]. The definitions below are local and apply to any complete manifold with boundary. Of the two main results that use them, the regularity theorem [LZ21, Theorem 6.2] has an entirely local proof (replacements, tangent cones, and boundary blow-ups all take place in a neighbourhood of a single point) and therefore extends to non-compact manifolds without modification. The only step requiring compactness of the ambient manifold is the combinatorial selection of almost minimizing varifolds [LZ21, Theorem 5.3]; in our setting this is handled by applying the argument on each bounded set in the exhaustion and passing to a diagonal subsequence, exactly as in [CL20, §7]. The details are carried out in Section 1.7.

The basic notion captures cycles whose mass cannot be decreased much by local deformations supported in a given open set.

Definition 1.7.4 (Almost minimizing with free boundary [LZ21, Definition 4.18])**.** Let $U \subset M$ be relatively open. For $\varepsilon, \delta > 0$, define $\mathscr{A}_n(U; \varepsilon, \delta; \mathcal{F})$ to be the set of all $\tau \in \mathbf{Z}_n(M, \partial M; \mathbb{Z}_2)$ such that whenever $\tau = \tau_0, \tau_1, \ldots, \tau_m \in \mathbf{Z}_n(M, \partial M; \mathbb{Z}_2)$ is a discrete sequence with

- $\operatorname{spt}(\tau_i - \tau) \subset U$,

- $\mathcal{F}(\tau_{i+1} - \tau_i) \leq \delta$,
- $\mathbf{M}(\tau_i) \leq \mathbf{M}(\tau) + \delta$ for $i = 1, \ldots, m$,

then $\mathbf{M}(\tau_m) \geq \mathbf{M}(\tau) - \varepsilon$.

A varifold $V \in \mathcal{V}_n(M)$ is *almost minimizing in U with free boundary* if there exist sequences $\varepsilon_i \to 0$, $\delta_i \to 0$, and $\tau_i \in \mathscr{A}_n(U; \varepsilon_i, \delta_i; \mathcal{F})$ with canonical representatives $T_i \in \tau_i$ such that $\mathbf{F}(|T_i|, V) \leq \varepsilon_i$.

For regularity, one needs the almost minimizing property to hold not just in a single open set but in sufficiently small annuli around every point; this ensures that every tangent cone is area-minimizing. At interior points, the annuli are ordinary; near the boundary, one uses half-annuli.

Definition 1.7.5 (Almost minimizing in small annuli [LZ21, Definition 5.1])**.** For $p \in M$ and $0 < s < r$, set

$$\mathcal{A}_{s,r}(p) := \begin{cases} B_r(p) \setminus \overline{B}_s(p) & \text{if } p \in \operatorname{int}(M), \\ B_r^+(p) \setminus \overline{B}_s^+(p) & \text{if } p \in \partial M, \end{cases}$$

where $B_r^+(p) := B_r(p) \cap M$. A varifold $V \in \mathcal{V}_n(M)$ is *almost minimizing in small annuli with free boundary* if for each $p \in M$ there exists $r_{\mathrm{am}}(p) > 0$ such that V is almost minimizing in $\mathcal{A}_{s,r}(p)$ with free boundary for all $0 < s < r \leq r_{\mathrm{am}}(p)$.

A first consequence is that the almost minimizing property already implies stationarity, so no separate stationarity assumption is needed in the regularity theorem.

Proposition 1.7.6 ([LZ21, Proposition 4.21])**.** *If $V \in \mathcal{V}_n(M)$ is almost minimizing in a relatively open set $U \subset M$ with free boundary, then V is stationary in U with free boundary.*

The main payoff is that almost minimizing in small annuli, combined with stationarity, gives full regularity. This is the deepest result in [LZ21],

relying on replacements, tangent cone classification, and boundary blow-up analysis.

Theorem 1.7.7 (Regularity [LZ21, Theorem 6.2])**.** *Let $2 \leq n \leq 6$. Suppose $V \in \mathcal{V}_n(M)$ is stationary in M with free boundary and almost minimizing in small annuli with free boundary. Then there exist $N \in \mathbb{N}$, positive integers $m_1, \ldots, m_N$, and smooth, compact, connected, almost properly embedded free boundary minimal hypersurfaces $(\Sigma_j, \partial\Sigma_j) \subset (M, \partial M)$ such that*

$$V = \sum_{j=1}^{N} m_j \, |\Sigma_j|.$$

The restriction $2 \leq n \leq 6$ ensures that the singular set is empty; for $n \geq 7$ it has Hausdorff dimension at most $n - 7$.

Proof of the main theorem

We now assemble the ingredients. Let $V \in \mathcal{V}_\infty^C(M)$ be the pulled-tight varifold limit from Proposition 1.7.3. In the compact setting, Li–Zhou [LZ21, Theorem 5.3] obtain the almost minimizing property from the combinatorial selection argument of Almgren–Pitts [Pit81]. The key observation for the non-compact case is that this argument is *local*: for each $p \in M$, one only deforms sweepouts inside a bounded neighbourhood of p. Since each U_j in the exhaustion is bounded, the combinatorial argument applies on U_j without modification, and a diagonal argument over j yields:

Proposition 1.7.8 (Almost minimizing selection)**.** *After passing to a further subsequence, V is almost minimizing in small annuli with free boundary (Definition 1.7.5).*

Combining Proposition 1.7.8 with the regularity theorem (Theorem 1.7.7), we obtain smooth structure. As noted in Section 1.7, the proof of Theorem 1.7.7 is entirely local, so it applies to our non-compact M without modification:

Proposition 1.7.9 (Regularity of the limit)**.** *There exist $N \in \mathbb{N}$, positive integers $m_1, \ldots, m_N$, and smooth, compact, connected, almost properly embedded free boundary minimal hypersurfaces $(\Sigma_j, \partial\Sigma_j) \subset (M, \partial M)$ such that $V = \sum_{j=1}^{N} m_j \, |\Sigma_j|$.*

With these preparations, we restate and prove the main theorem (Theorem 1.1.1).

Theorem 1.7.10 (Main Theorem)**.** *Let (M^{n+1}, g) be a complete Riemannian manifold with non-empty smooth boundary ∂M, $2 \leq n \leq 6$. Let $U \subset M$ be a* good set *(Definition 1.2.20), i.e., a bounded open set of finite perimeter satisfying $\mathbf{M}(\partial_I U) \leq \frac{1}{10} W_\partial(U)$, with $\overline{U} \cap \partial M \neq \varnothing$. Then there exists a smooth, almost properly embedded minimal hypersurface $(\Sigma, \partial\Sigma) \subset (M, \partial M)$ with (possibly empty) boundary $\partial\Sigma \subset \partial M$ such that*

(i) *Σ is minimal in the interior and meets ∂M orthogonally along $\partial\Sigma$;*

(ii) (Area bound) *$\mathcal{H}^n(\Sigma) \leq W_\partial(U) + \mathbf{M}(\partial_I U)$;*

(iii) (Localization) *$\Sigma \cap \overline{U} \neq \varnothing$.*

Proof. The proof combines all preceding chapters in three steps.

Step 1: Min–max sequence. The good set condition gives $W_g(U) > 0$: indeed, $\mathbf{M}(\partial_I U) \leq \frac{1}{10} W_\partial(U)$ implies $W_\partial(U) > 0$, and Proposition 1.2.19 gives $W_g(U) \geq W_\partial(U) - \mathbf{M}(\partial_I U) \geq \frac{9}{10} W_\partial(U) > 0$.

By Proposition 1.5.1, there exist good sweepouts $\{\Gamma_t^i\}$ of U with $\sup_t \mathbf{M}(\Gamma_t^i) \downarrow W_g(U)$. The pull–tight procedure (Section 1.7) produces a minimizing sequence $\{\mathbf{P}_i(\Gamma_t^i)\}$ whose varifold limit V is stationary in M with free boundary (Proposition 1.7.3).

Step 2: Regularity. By Propositions 1.7.8 and 1.7.9,

$$V = \sum_{j=1}^{N} m_j \, |\Sigma_j|,$$

where each $(\Sigma_j, \partial\Sigma_j) \subset (M, \partial M)$ is a smooth, compact, connected, almost properly embedded minimal hypersurface meeting ∂M orthogonally along $\partial\Sigma_j$. Set $\Sigma := \bigcup_{j=1}^{N} \Sigma_j$.

Step 3: Area bound and localization. The area bound follows from the width inequalities (Proposition 1.2.19):

$$\mathcal{H}^n(\Sigma) \leq \|V\|(M) = W_g(U) \leq W_\partial(U) + \mathbf{M}(\partial_I U).$$

For the localization, the non-escape estimate (Proposition 1.6.1) guarantees $\mathcal{H}^n(\Sigma \cap \overline{U}) \geq \varepsilon(U) > 0$, so in particular $\Sigma \cap \overline{U} \neq \varnothing$. □

As an immediate corollary, we obtain existence under a volume growth condition.

Corollary 1.7.11. *Let (M^{n+1}, g) be a complete Riemannian manifold with non-empty smooth boundary ∂M, $2 \leq n \leq 6$, and sublinear volume growth:*

$$\liminf_{R\to\infty} \frac{\mathcal{H}^{n+1}(B_R(x) \cap M)}{R} = 0 \qquad \textit{for some } x \in M.$$

Suppose in addition that there exists a good set U with $\overline{U} \cap \partial M \neq \varnothing$ (e.g., when ∂M is non-compact). Then M contains a smooth, almost properly embedded minimal hypersurface $(\Sigma, \partial\Sigma) \subset (M, \partial M)$ satisfying conclusions (i)–(iii) *of Theorem 1.7.10.*

Proof. By Lemma 1.2.21, the sublinear growth condition guarantees the existence of a good set $U \subset M$ with $\overline{U} \cap \partial M \neq \varnothing$. The result follows from Theorem 1.7.10. □

2

PART 2: ALTERNATIVE REGULARITY VIA NON-EXCESSIVE SWEEPOUTS

2.1 INTRODUCTION

In the classical Almgren–Pitts min-max theory [Alm65, Pit81], the regularity of the min-max hypersurface is established through two key ingredients: the *almost minimizing* property, which is obtained from a combinatorial selection argument, and the Schoen–Simon regularity theory [SS81] for stable minimal hypersurfaces. The framework operates with integral currents, so integrality of the limit object is built into the construction from the outset.

Chodosh–Liokumovich–Spolaor [CLS22] introduced an alternative approach to min-max theory based on *non-excessive sweepouts*. Rather than working with integral currents, their framework operates with varifolds and sweepouts by Caccioppoli sets. The non-excessive condition—roughly, that critical slices of the sweepout cannot be locally replaced by competitors of strictly smaller mass—provides structural control that replaces the almost minimizing property of Almgren–Pitts. This approach has led to striking applications, including generic regularity of min-max hypersurfaces in dimension 8 and a bound relating the Morse index to the number of non-area-minimizing singularities [CLS22].

A key step in the non-excessive framework is the construction of *optimal nested sweepouts*: optimal sweepouts whose sublevel sets are monotonically increasing. The existence of such sweepouts relies on the monotonisation technique of Chambers–Liokumovich [CL20], which converts arbitrary sweepouts into nested ones with controlled mass increase. The nested sweepout machinery developed in Part 1 of this thesis (Sections 1.3–1.5) provides exactly this input.

In this chapter, we explore an alternative path to regularity within the non-excessive framework: instead of the Schoen–Simon theory, we use Wickramasekera's regularity theorem [Wic14] for stable codimension 1 integral varifolds. Wickramasekera's theorem gives optimal regularity (empty singular set for $2 \leq n \leq 6$) under two hypotheses: (i) the varifold is a stable integral varifold, and (ii) it satisfies the *α-structural hypothesis* for some $\alpha \in (0, 1/2)$—no singular point has a neighbourhood in which the support consists of three or more embedded $C^{1,\alpha}$ hypersurfaces-with-boundary meeting only along their common boundary. Combining these tools, we obtain:

Main result (informal)**.** *Let (M^{n+1}, g) be a closed Riemannian manifold with $2 \leq n \leq 6$. Then the non-excessive min-max construction, using nested sweepouts as input and Wickramasekera's theorem for regularity, produces a smooth, closed, embedded minimal hypersurface, provided no mass cancellation occurs.*

The proof proceeds in three steps. First, we show that in the absence of mass cancellation, the limit varifold is integral: since the varifold mass equals the width, the approximating Caccioppoli sets converge with no loss of perimeter, and the De Lellis–Tasnady integrality criterion [DLT13, Proposition A.1] applies. Second, we verify the α-structural hypothesis by analyzing blow-up cones at potential singular points and using the non-excessive condition to rule out configurations where three or more sheets meet. Third, the non-excessive structure also ensures stability (or one-sided minimization), so Wickramasekera's theorem [Wic14] (or the one-sided regularity of Liu [Liu19]) yields smoothness.

The mass cancellation problem. The mass cancellation case—where the current masses $\mathbf{M}(\Phi(x_i))$ converge to the width W but $\mathbf{M}(\Phi(x_0)) < W$ at the limit parameter x_0—remains an open problem. In this situation, sheets of the Caccioppoli boundaries with opposite orientations cancel in the flat topology while contributing positively to varifold mass, and the De Lellis–Tasnady criterion no longer applies. Establishing integrality of the limit varifold without the no-cancellation hypothesis appears to require fundamentally new ideas, and we formulate this as a conjecture (Conjecture 2.3.2).

Organization. Section 2.2 reviews the non-excessive sweepout framework of [CLS22], including the definitions of excessive intervals, non-excessive points, and homotopic minimizers. Section 2.4 establishes integrality of the limit varifold without mass cancellation and discusses the mass cancellation case as an open problem. The final section verifies the α-structural hypothesis via Wickramasekera's regularity theorem [Wic14] and completes the proof of the main theorem.

2.2 NON-EXCESSIVE SWEEPOUTS

An alternative approach to min–max theory, developed by Chodosh–Liokumovich–Spolaor [CLS22], is based on the notion of *non-excessive sweepouts*. The non-excessive condition provides additional structural control that simplifies the regularity analysis.

We use the notation from Section 1.2. Recall that a sweepout $\{\Omega_t\}_{t\in[0,1]}$ of M is a continuous family of Caccioppoli sets with $\Omega_0 = \emptyset$ and $\Omega_1 = M$ (Definition 1.2.13). The width is $W = W(M)$ as in Definition 1.2.14.

Definition 2.2.1 (Optimal nested volume parametrized sweepout)**.** A sweepout $\{\Phi(x) = \partial\Omega(x)\}$ is called

- *optimal* if $\mathcal{F}(\Phi) = W$;
- *nested* if $\Omega(x_1) \subset \Omega(x_2)$ for all $0 \le x_1 \le x_2 \le 1$ (cf. Definition 1.2.17);

- *volume parametrized* if $\mathrm{Vol}(\Omega(x)) = x$ for every $x \in [0,1]$.

We call such a sweepout an *optimal nested volume parametrized (ONVP) sweepout*.

Definition 2.2.2 (Critical set)**.** Given a sweepout Φ, define

$$M(x) = \limsup_{r \to 0} \{\mathbf{M}(\Phi(y)) : |y - x| < r\}.$$

If Φ is an optimal sweepout, the *critical domain of* Φ is

$$\mathfrak{m}(\Phi) = \{x \in [0,1] : M(x) = W\}.$$

We denote by $\mathfrak{m}_L(\Phi)$ and $\mathfrak{m}_R(\Phi)$ the sets of left and right critical points.

Excessive Intervals and Non-Excessive Points

We introduce the concept of excessive intervals, which identify portions of a sweepout that can be replaced by lower-mass competitors.

Definition 2.2.3 (Excessive intervals and points)**.** Suppose $\{\Phi(x) = \partial\Omega(x)\}$ is a sweepout. Given a connected interval $I \subset [0,1]$ (which may be open, closed, or half-open), we say that $\{\Phi^I(x) = \partial\Omega^I(x)\}_{x \in \bar{I}}$ is an *I-replacement family for* Φ if $\Omega^I(a) = \Omega(a)$, $\Omega^I(b) = \Omega(b)$ at the endpoints, and for all $x \in I$,

$$\limsup_{I \ni y \to x} \mathbf{M}(\Phi^I(y)) < W,$$

where $W := \mathcal{F}(\Phi)$.

We say that a connected interval I is an *excessive interval for* Φ if there exists an I-replacement family for Φ. A point x is called *left excessive for* Φ (resp. *right excessive*) if there exists an excessive interval I with $(x - \varepsilon, x] \subset I$ (resp. $[x, x + \varepsilon) \subset I$) for some $\varepsilon > 0$.

Non-Excessive Sweepouts and Stationary Varifolds

The fundamental result of Chodosh–Liokumovich–Spolaor is the existence of sweepouts where critical points are not excessive:

Theorem 2.2.4 (Existence of non-excessive min-max hypersurface [CLS22, Theorem 3.1])**.** *Let (M^{n+1}, g) be a closed Riemannian manifold with $2 \leq n \leq 6$. There exists an (ONVP) sweepout Ψ such that every $x \in \mathfrak{m}_L(\Psi)$ is not left excessive and every $x \in \mathfrak{m}_R(\Psi)$ is not right excessive.*

A sweepout satisfying the conclusion of Theorem 2.2.4 is called a *non-excessive sweepout*. We denote by $\mathcal{S}_{\mathrm{nm}}$ the collection of all such sweepouts.

Proposition 2.2.5 (Stationary varifolds from optimal sweepouts)**.** *Let (M^{n+1}, g) be a closed Riemannian manifold with $2 \leq n \leq 6$, and let Φ be an optimal sweepout with $\mathcal{F}(\Phi) = W$ (the min-max width). Then there exists a stationary n-varifold V in M with $\mathbf{M}(V) \leq W$.*

Proof. Each slice $\Phi(x) = \partial\Omega(x)$ induces a varifold $V_x = |\partial^*\Omega(x)|$. Let $\{x_i\}$ be any sequence with $\mathbf{M}(\Phi(x_i)) \to W$. By varifold compactness, some subsequence satisfies $V_{x_i} \overset{*}{\rightharpoonup} V$ with $\|V\|(M) \leq W$. We claim some such limit V is stationary.

Suppose not: every varifold limit of sequences $\{V_{x_i}\}$ with $\mathbf{M}(\Phi(x_i)) \to W$ is non-stationary. Consider $A_\eta = \{x : \mathbf{M}(\Phi(x)) \geq W - \eta\}$, which is compact. By assumption, for each $x \in A_\eta$, any limit point of $\{V_y\}_{y \to x}$ is non-stationary. The tightening flow of [CL03] strictly decreases mass near non-stationary varifolds, so by compactness of A_η, there exists $\varepsilon > 0$ (depending on η) such that tightening decreases mass by at least ε on A_η.

Choose $\eta < \varepsilon$. After tightening, slices from A_η have mass $\leq W - \varepsilon < W - \eta$, and slices outside A_η already had mass $< W - \eta$. Thus the tightened sweepout $\tilde{\Phi}$ satisfies $\sup_x \mathbf{M}(\tilde{\Phi}(x)) < W$, contradicting the definition of width. $\square$

This is the standard pull-tight argument of [CL03]. Note that the non-excessive condition is not used here; it will be essential later for establishing stability and controlling mass cancellation.

Remark 2.2.6. The varifold V obtained from Proposition 2.2.5 is stationary, but its *integrality* is not automatically guaranteed. This is the key issue that distinguishes the non-excessive framework from the classical Almgren–Pitts approach:

- In Almgren–Pitts theory, one works with integral currents $\mathbf{Z}_n(M; \mathbb{Z}_2)$ from the outset, so integrality is built into the framework.
- In the non-excessive framework, one works with varifolds, and integrality must be established separately.
- Both approaches use pull-tight to obtain stationarity, but pull-tight alone does not produce integrality.

Homotopic Minimizers and Non-Minimizing Points

To analyze the geometric properties of min-max varifolds, we introduce the notion of homotopic minimizers and points where this property fails.

Definition 2.2.7 (Homotopic minimizers)**.** Let $\Sigma = \partial^*\Omega$ be a Caccioppoli set in M, and let $U \subset M$ be an open set. We say that Σ is:

- *inner homotopic minimizing in U* if there is no Caccioppoli set $E \subset \Omega$ with $E \triangle \Omega \subset U$ and $\mathrm{per}(E, U) < \mathrm{per}(\Omega, U)$ that can be connected to Ω by a continuous family of Caccioppoli sets in U;
- *outer homotopic minimizing in U* if there is no Caccioppoli set $E \supset \Omega$ with $E \triangle \Omega \subset U$ and $\mathrm{per}(E, U) < \mathrm{per}(\Omega, U)$ that can be connected to Ω by a continuous family of Caccioppoli sets in U;
- *one-sided homotopic minimizing in U* if it is either inner or outer homotopic minimizing in U.

Definition 2.2.8 (Non-homotopic-minimizing points)**.** For a varifold V arising from a min-max procedure, we define the set of *non-homotopic-minimizing points* by

$$\mathfrak{h}_{\mathrm{nm}}(V) := \left\{ P \in \mathbf{spt}\|V\| : \begin{array}{l} \text{for all } r > 0 \text{ small, } \mathbf{spt}\|V\| \cap B_r(P) \text{ is not one-sided} \\ \text{homotopic area minimizing on either side in } B_r(P) \end{array} \right\}.$$

Intuitively, $\mathfrak{h}_{\mathrm{nm}}(V)$ consists of points where the varifold V cannot be approximated by one-sided area minimizers in any neighborhood. These notions will be used in Section 2.5 to verify the α-structural hypothesis required by Wickramasekera's regularity theorem.

The Integrality Issue

Following [CLS22], we distinguish two cases for a critical point $x_0 \in \mathfrak{m}(\Phi)$ of a non-excessive sweepout Φ:

Definition 2.2.9 (Mass cancellation)**.** Let Φ be a non-excessive (ONVP) sweepout with width W, and let $x_0 \in \mathfrak{m}(\Phi)$ be a critical point. We say that:

- *No mass cancellation* occurs at x_0 if $\mathbf{M}(\Phi(x_0)) = W$.
- *Mass cancellation* occurs at x_0 if $\mathbf{M}(\Phi(x_0)) < W$.

Without mass cancellation, the limiting varifold V equals $|\partial\Omega(x_0)|$ with no mass loss. With mass cancellation, V may have larger mass than $\mathbf{M}(\partial\Omega(x_0))$ due to sheets with opposite orientations canceling in the current while contributing to varifold mass.

In this chapter, we establish integrality and regularity without mass cancellation via Wickramasekera's theorem. The case with mass cancellation remains open.

2.3 MAIN RESULT

Theorem 2.3.1 (Existence of minimal hypersurfaces via non-excessive min-max)**.** *Let (M^{n+1}, g) be a closed Riemannian manifold with $2 \leq n \leq 6$. Then there exists a smooth closed embedded minimal hypersurface in M.*

Conjecture 2.3.2 (Integrality with mass cancellation)**.** *If the tightened stationary varifold is integral even in the presence of mass cancellation, then Wickramasekera's regularity theorem remains applicable, and the conclusion of Theorem 2.3.1 extends to this case as well.*

2.4 INTEGRALITY WITHOUT MASS CANCELLATION

Theorem 2.4.1 (Integrality without mass cancellation)**.** *Let (M^{n+1}, g) be a closed Riemannian manifold with $n \geq 2$, and let V be a stationary varifold arising from a non-excessive sweepout via the construction of Theorem 2.2.5. If $\Theta^n(V, x) = 1$ for $\mathbf{M}(V)$-almost every $x \in \mathbf{spt}(V)$, then V is integral and rectifiable.*

Case 1: No Mass Loss

The reduced boundary $\partial^*\Omega$ of a Caccioppoli set Ω induces a varifold $V = \mathcal{H}^n \llcorner \partial^*\Omega \otimes \delta_{T_x\partial^*\Omega}$.

The key tool is the following proposition from the appendix of De Lellis–Tasnady [DLT13]:

Proposition 2.4.2 (Varifolds vs Caccioppoli set limits [DLT13, Proposition A.1])**.** *Let $\{\Omega^k\}$ be a sequence of Caccioppoli sets and U an open subset of M. Assume that*

(i) $D\mathbb{1}_{\Omega^k} \to D\mathbb{1}_\Omega$ in the sense of measures in U;

(ii) $\mathrm{per}(\Omega^k, U) \to \mathrm{per}(\Omega, U)$

for some Caccioppoli set Ω. Denote by V^k and V the varifolds induced by $\partial^*\Omega^k$ and $\partial^*\Omega$ respectively, where $\partial^*\Omega$ denotes the reduced boundary. Then $V^k \to V$ in the sense of varifolds.

Proof of Theorem 2.4.1, Case 1. By Theorem 2.2.5, the varifold V arises as the weak limit of varifolds V_i associated to slices $T_i = \phi(t_i)$ with $\mathbf{M}(T_i) \to \mathcal{F}(\phi)$.

We identify each slice $T_i \in \mathbf{Z}_n(M; \mathbb{Z}_2)$ with its corresponding Caccioppoli set Ω_i (see Proposition 1.2.4). The varifold V_i is then the varifold induced by the reduced boundary $\partial^*\Omega_i$, given by

$$V_i = \mathcal{H}^n \llcorner \partial^*\Omega_i \otimes \delta_{T_x \partial^*\Omega_i}.$$

Step 1: BV convergence. By the compactness theorem for BV functions (Caccioppoli sets), the sequence $\{\Omega_i\}$ has a subsequence (still denoted $\{\Omega_i\}$) such that $D\mathbb{1}_{\Omega_i} \to D\mathbb{1}_\Omega$ weakly in the sense of measures, for some Caccioppoli set Ω.

Step 2: Perimeter convergence. We establish perimeter convergence using the no mass cancellation hypothesis.

By passing to a subsequence, we may assume $t_i \to t^*$ for some $t^* \in [0, 1]$. Since $\mathbf{M}(\phi(t_i)) \to W = \mathcal{F}(\phi)$ and the function $M(x) := \limsup_{r\to 0}\{\mathbf{M}(\phi(y)) : |y - x| < r\}$ is upper semicontinuous, we have $M(t^*) \geq W$. But $M(x) \leq W$ for all x by definition of width, so $M(t^*) = W$, i.e., $t^* \in \mathfrak{m}(\phi)$.

By the *no mass cancellation* hypothesis (Definition 2.2.9), we have

$$\mathbf{M}(\phi(t^*)) = W.$$

Since the sweepout ϕ is continuous in the flat norm topology (see Proposition 1.2.15), and flat convergence implies L^1 convergence of characteristic

functions, we have $\mathbb{1}_{\Omega_i} \to \mathbb{1}_{\Omega(t^*)}$ in $L^1(M)$. By uniqueness of BV limits, the Caccioppoli set Ω from Step 1 equals $\Omega(t^*)$.

Now we can establish perimeter convergence directly:

- **Upper bound:** By the identification of currents and Caccioppoli sets,

$$\mathrm{per}(\Omega_i, M) = \mathbf{M}(\phi(t_i)) \to W.$$

- **Lower bound:** By lower semicontinuity of perimeter under BV convergence,

$$\mathrm{per}(\Omega, M) \leq \liminf_{i\to\infty} \mathrm{per}(\Omega_i, M) = W.$$

- **Equality:** Since $\Omega = \Omega(t^*)$ and $\mathbf{M}(\phi(t^*)) = W$ by no mass cancellation,

$$\mathrm{per}(\Omega, M) = \mathrm{per}(\Omega(t^*), M) = \mathbf{M}(\phi(t^*)) = W.$$

Combining these, we obtain perimeter convergence:

$$\mathrm{per}(\Omega_i, M) \to \mathrm{per}(\Omega, M) = W.$$

Step 3: Application of Proposition 2.4.2. By Proposition 2.4.2 (De Lellis–Tasnady, Proposition A.1), since we have both BV convergence and perimeter convergence, the varifold limit V equals the varifold induced by $\partial^*\Omega$:

$$V = \mathcal{H}^n \llcorner \partial^*\Omega \otimes \delta_{T_x\partial^*\Omega}.$$

This is precisely the varifold induced by an integral current (the Caccioppoli set Ω), hence V is integral and rectifiable. $\square$

Case 2: Mass Cancellation

In this case, we assume that $\mathbf{M}(\Phi(x_0)) < W$, so that mass cancellation occurs at the critical point x_0. As noted in Conjecture 2.3.2, establishing integrality in this case remains an open problem.

Proposition 2.4.3 (Regularity assuming Conjecture 2.3.2)**.** *Suppose Conjecture 2.3.2 holds, so that the stationary varifold V arising from a non-excessive sweepout is integral even in the presence of mass cancellation. Then the same regularity argument as in Case 1 applies, and V is a smooth embedded minimal hypersurface.*

Remark 2.4.4. The fundamental obstruction to proving Conjecture 2.3.2 is that when $\mathbf{M}(V) < W$, we cannot apply the index bound $\mathrm{Index}(V) \leq 1$ from min-max, which prevents us from using Wickramasekera's regularity theory to establish integrality. This represents a genuine obstruction rather than merely a technical gap.

Proof. If V is integral, then by Proposition 2.4.2, there exists a Caccioppoli set Ω such that

$$V = \mathcal{H}^n \llcorner \partial^* \Omega \otimes \delta_{T_x \partial^* \Omega}.$$

The reduced boundary $\partial^*\Omega$ is $(n-1)$-rectifiable by De Giorgi's theorem, hence V is rectifiable and integral.

The regularity then follows from Wickramasekera's theorem (Theorem 2.5.1) once we verify the α-structural hypothesis, which can be done using the same deformation arguments as in Section 2.5 for the case without mass cancellation. □

2.5 REGULARITY VIA WICKRAMASEKERA'S THEOREM

We recall the main regularity result from Wickramasekera [Wic14]:

Theorem 2.5.1 (Wickramasekera [Wic14]). *Let V be a stable integral n-varifold in a closed $(n+1)$-dimensional Riemannian manifold with $2 \leq n \leq 6$. Suppose that for some $\alpha \in (0, 1/2)$, V satisfies the α-structural hypothesis (Definition 2.5.2). Then $\mathbf{sing} V = \emptyset$, i.e., $\mathbf{spt}(V)$ is a smooth embedded minimal hypersurface.*

Definition 2.5.2 (α-structural hypothesis). For $\alpha \in (0, 1/2)$, a stationary integral varifold V satisfies the *α-structural hypothesis* if **no singular point** of V has a neighborhood in which V corresponds to a union of embedded $C^{1,\alpha}$ hypersurfaces-with-boundary meeting *only* along their common $C^{1,\alpha}$ boundary, and with multiplicity a constant positive integer on each of the constituent hypersurfaces-with-boundary.

Remark 2.5.3. By Wickramasekera's theorem, the following are equivalent for a stable integral n-varifold V:

(a) V satisfies the α-structural hypothesis for some $\alpha \in (0, 1/2)$.

(b) $\mathbf{sing} V = \emptyset$ if $2 \leq n \leq 6$.

(c) $\mathcal{H}^{n-1}(\mathbf{sing} V) = 0$ (vanishing $(n-1)$-dimensional Hausdorff measure of the singular set).

Thus, to prove regularity via Wickramasekera's theorem, it suffices to verify the α-structural hypothesis for some $\alpha \in (0, 1/2)$.

Verification of the α-Structural Hypothesis

Theorem 2.5.4 (Verification of α-structural hypothesis). *Let V be the stationary integral varifold from Theorem 2.4.1 arising from a non-excessive sweepout without mass cancellation. Then V satisfies the α-structural hypothesis.*

Case 1: No Mass Cancellation

Assume the *no cancellation* condition:

$$\mathbf{M}(\Phi(x_0)) = W, \tag{2.1}$$

where W is the min-max width and x_0 is a critical point.

In this case, the stationary integral varifold V from Theorem 2.4.1 can be written as $V = |\Sigma| = |\partial^*\Omega|$ for some Caccioppoli set Ω.

Our proof of Theorem 2.5.4 under the no cancellation condition is similar to [CLS22, Lemma 3.4].

Remark 2.5.5 (Why the case analysis is complete). We explain why Cases 1a and 1b below are exhaustive, and why stability holds.

(1) Completeness of cases. Since $V = |\partial\Omega|$ in the no mass cancellation case, tangent cones at singular points are constrained by the Caccioppoli set structure. For stationary boundaries of Caccioppoli sets in $\mathbb{R}^{n+1}$ ($n \leq 6$), the only possible singular cones are:

- **Case 1a:** $C = |H_1| + |H_2|$ (two half-hyperplanes meeting at angle $< \pi$) — a "wedge"
- **Case 1b:** $C = 2|H|$ (single half-hyperplane with multiplicity 2) — a "fold"

Higher multiplicities ($q \geq 3$) or more complex configurations (three or more sheets meeting) would require mass cancellation, which is impossible for Caccioppoli boundaries.

(2) Stability. The min-max construction gives $\mathrm{Index}(V) \leq 1$. Combined with the deformation arguments below showing at most one unstable direction, we conclude $\mathrm{Index}(V) = 0$ (stability) or $\mathrm{Index}(V) = 1$ (one-sided minimization), both of which lead to regularity via Wickramasekera [Wic14] or Liu [Liu19].

Proof of Theorem 2.5.4, Case 1. Suppose the α-structural hypothesis fails at $Z \in \mathbf{sing}V$. Then there exists $\rho > 0$ such that

$$B_\rho(Z)\backslash\mathbf{spt}\|V\| = \left(\bigsqcup_{i=1}^{N} E_i\right) \sqcup \left(\bigsqcup_{j=1}^{N} F_j\right), \tag{2.2}$$

and we denote $\mathcal{E} := \bigsqcup_{i=1}^{N} E_i$ (resp. $\mathcal{F} := \bigsqcup_{j=1}^{N} F_j$) to represent those Caccioppoli sets within $\overline{\Omega}$ (resp. $\overline{\Omega^c}$).

Without loss of generality, we only need to show that the E_i are not homotopic minimizers. For each $i = 1, \ldots, N$, we denote by C the blow-up cone of E_i at Z. Then there are only two possibilities for the structure of the cone:

- **Case 1a:** $C = |H_1| + |H_2|$ where both H_1 and H_2 are half-hyperplanes gluing along their common boundaries with the angle between them less than π.

  We denote $C = |\partial^*\Omega_C|$ for some Caccioppoli set Ω_C of $\mathbb{R}^{n+1}$. In this case, as in [CLS22, Lemma 3.4], we can choose $C^{1,\alpha}$-coordinates on M around Z such that $E_i = \Omega_C$ in $B_\varepsilon(Z)$ so that $g_{ij}(Z) = \delta_{ij}$, which we can do since $g \in C^2$ and $\Sigma = |\partial^* E_i|$ is a $C^{1,\alpha}$-deformation of C near Z by assumption.

  Since the angle between H_1 and H_2 is less than π, by the optimal regularity theorem for one-sided minimizers from [Liu19], we can find a Caccioppoli set $E_C \subset \Omega_C$ so that $E_C \triangle \Omega_C \subset B_1 \subset \mathbb{R}^{n+1}$ and

  $$\mathrm{per}_{\mathbb{R}^{n+1}}(E_C, B_1) \leq \mathrm{per}_{\mathbb{R}^{n+1}}(\Omega_C, B_1) - \delta \tag{2.3}$$

  for some $\delta > 0$. We set

  $$E(x) := \begin{cases} (E_i\backslash B_\varepsilon(Z)) \cup (|x|E_C \cap B_\varepsilon(Z)) & x < 0 \\ E_i & x = 0. \end{cases} \tag{2.4}$$

We have that

$$\mathrm{per}_g(E(x)) - \mathrm{per}_g(\Omega) = -|x|^n \delta(1 + o(1)) \tag{2.5}$$

as $x \to 0$. This shows that Σ is not inner homotopic minimizing.

- **Case 1b:** $C = 2|H|$ where H is a half-hyperplane. In this case, we define

$$E(x) := \begin{cases} E_i \backslash B_{|x|}(Z) & x < 0 \\ E_i & x = 0. \end{cases} \tag{2.6}$$

Apparently, for any $r > 0$,

$$\mathbf{M}_{B_1}(H \backslash B_r(0)) = \mathbf{M}_{B_1}(H) - \frac{1}{2}\omega_n r^n. \tag{2.7}$$

Moreover, since E_i is also a two-valued $C^{1,\alpha}$ graph over H and $|H|$ is the blow-up cone of $|\partial^* E_i|$ at Z, we know that $\mathrm{per}_g(E_i, B_{|x|}(Z)) = o(1)|x|^n$. Thus, we can again conclude that

$$\mathrm{per}_g(E(x)) - \mathrm{per}_g(\Omega) = -|x|^n \delta(1 + o(1)), \tag{2.8}$$

where $\delta = \omega_n/2$.

We can define the corresponding $F(x)$ for F_j by changing $x < 0$ to $x > 0$. Thus, we can know that $Z \in \mathfrak{h}_{nm}(\Sigma)$, where $\mathfrak{h}_{nm}$ denotes the set of points that are not homotopic minimizing in the sense of [CLS22]:

$$\mathfrak{h}_{nm}(V) := \left\{ P \in \mathbf{spt}\|V\| : \begin{array}{l} \text{for all } r > 0 \text{ small, } \mathbf{spt}\,\|V\| \cap B_r(P) \text{ is not one-sided} \\ \text{homotopic area minimizing on either side in } B_r(P) \end{array} \right\}. \tag{2.9}$$

Since $Z \in \mathfrak{h}_{nm}(V)$, by [CLS22, Proposition 3.1], we know that there is ρ sufficiently small such that for every $X \notin B_\rho(Z)$, there exists $r > 0$ such that $\mathbf{spt}\|V\|$ is one-sided minimizing in $B_r(X)$. However, since the α-structural hypothesis fails, we can take $X \in \mathbf{sing}V$ with $X \notin B_\rho(Z)$ such

that $\mathbf{spt}\|V\| \cap B_r(X)$ has $(n-1)$-dimensional singularity, which contradicts the optimal regularity for one-sided minimizers from [Liu19].

Remark 2.5.6 (Dimension of the singular set). The proof above uses the existence of singular points $X \in \mathbf{sing}V$ outside $B_\rho(Z)$. We explain why such points exist.

If the α-structural hypothesis fails at Z, then by Cases 1a and 1b, the tangent cone at Z has an $(n-1)$-dimensional "spine" L—the common boundary of the half-hyperplanes. Since V approximates this cone in the Hausdorff sense near Z, the singular set $\mathbf{sing}V$ must contain an $(n-1)$-dimensional subset near Z, not just an isolated point. In particular, for any $\rho > 0$, there exist singular points $X \in \mathbf{sing}V \setminus B_\rho(Z)$ where the same structural analysis applies, leading to the contradiction in the proof.

Therefore, the α-structural hypothesis must hold. □

The min-max construction gives $\mathrm{index}(V) \leq 1$. This index bound holds *a priori* before regularity is established, avoiding any circular reasoning.

Thus if V is stable (i.e., $\mathrm{index}(V) = 0$), then Wickramasekera's regularity theorem [Wic14] guarantees the optimal regularity for V. And in the case when $\mathrm{index}(V) = 1$, V is one-sided area minimizing, thus we can again use the optimal regularity for one-sided minimizers from [Liu19].

Case 2: Mass Cancellation

Assume the *cancellation* condition: $\mathbf{M}(\Phi(x_0)) < W$ throughout this section.

In this case, strict mass cancellation occurs: there exists a cancellation point $q \in \mathrm{reg}\, V$ such that

$$\mathrm{per}(\Omega, B_\varepsilon(q)) < |V|(B_\varepsilon(q))$$

for all sufficiently small $\varepsilon > 0$, where $\Omega = \Omega(x_0)$ and V can be written as $V = \sum_i \kappa_i |\Sigma_i|$ for integer multiplicities κ_i.

Remark 2.5.7 (Integrality assumption). The representation $V = \sum_i \kappa_i |\Sigma_i|$ with *integer* multiplicities assumes integrality, which is precisely what Conjecture 2.3.2 seeks to establish. The analysis below should be understood as conditional on this conjecture. The fundamental obstruction to proving integrality in the mass cancellation case is that without $\mathbf{M}(V) = W$, we cannot apply the index bound to deduce regularity.

The key difference from Case 1 is that Σ need not be globally representable as $\partial^*\Omega$; instead, it may consist of multiple components with different multiplicities. Nevertheless, the cancellation condition allows us to control deformations away from the cancellation point q.

Definition 2.5.8 (Competitors in the cancellation case)**.** Given $\varepsilon, \tau > 0$ with $\Sigma = \mathbf{spt}(V) \subset \overline{\Omega}$, we call a Caccioppoli set Ω' a $(q, \varepsilon, \tau, \Sigma, \Omega)$*-competitor* if

$$(\Omega \setminus B_\tau(\Sigma)) \cup (B_\varepsilon(q) \setminus \Sigma) \subset \Omega' \subsetneq \Omega \setminus \Sigma.$$

A $(q, \varepsilon, \tau, \Sigma, \Omega)$-competitor Ω' is called a *minimizing competitor* if its perimeter is strictly less than the perimeter of any $(q, \varepsilon, \tau, \Sigma, \Omega)$-competitor Ω'' with $\Omega' \subset \Omega''$.

Intuitively, a competitor represents a Caccioppoli set that:

- Agrees with Ω outside a τ-neighborhood of Σ;
- Agrees with Ω near the cancellation point q (in $B_\varepsilon(q)$);
- Has strictly smaller perimeter than Ω in the intermediate region.

The key technical result is that such competitors cannot exist when x_0 is not excessive:

Proposition 2.5.9 (Non-existence of minimizing competitors [CLS22, Proposition 6.3])**.** *Suppose V arises from a non-excessive sweepout Φ with $x_i \nearrow x_0 \in \mathfrak{m}_L(\Phi)$ and $|\Phi(x_i)| \to V$, and suppose the cancellation condition $\mathbf{M}(\Phi(x_0)) < W$ holds. Then for every $\varepsilon > 0$, there exists $\tau > 0$ such that no minimizing $(q, \varepsilon, \tau, \Sigma, \Omega)$-competitor exists.*

Proof sketch. Suppose a minimizing competitor U exists. By the cancellation condition, we can find Caccioppoli sets Ω' with $\mathrm{per}(\Omega') \leq W + \eta - \delta(\varepsilon)$ for small η and $\delta(\varepsilon) > 0$ from the mass loss at q. The minimizing property of U implies $\mathrm{per}(U) < W$.

For τ sufficiently small, a continuity argument (as in [CLS22, Lemma 3.3]) provides a nested family $\{E(x) : x \in [0,1]\}$ with $E(0) = U$, $E(1) = \Omega(x_0)$, and $\mathrm{per}(E(x)) < W$. Combining this with the original sweepout produces a replacement family showing that x_0 is left excessive, contradicting Theorem 2.2.4. □

With the non-existence of minimizing competitors established, we can prove regularity (conditional on Conjecture 2.3.2):

Proof of Theorem 2.5.4, Case 2 (assuming integrality). By Proposition 2.5.9, there are no minimizing competitors for any $\varepsilon > 0$ and suitable $\tau > 0$. This implies:

Stability of V: If any component Σ_i had unstable regular part, one could perform a one-sided minimization in $B_\tau(\Sigma_i) \setminus B_\varepsilon(q)$ to find a minimizing competitor, contradicting Proposition 2.5.9. Thus each Σ_i has stable regular part.

$\mathfrak{h}_{\mathrm{nm}}(V) = \emptyset$: By [CLS22, Proposition 3.7], the non-existence of minimizing competitors implies that every point of V is one-sided area minimizing in a small neighborhood. Therefore, $\mathfrak{h}_{\mathrm{nm}}(V) = \emptyset$.

Verification of α-structural hypothesis: If the α-structural hypothesis fails at some point $Z \in \mathbf{sing}V$, we can construct a local area-reducing deformation as in Case 1. However, such a deformation would produce a minimizing competitor (by one-sided minimization), contradicting Proposition 2.5.9.

Therefore, V satisfies all hypotheses of Wickramasekera's theorem [Wic14], implying smoothness. □

Proof of the Main Theorem

We are now ready to prove Theorem 2.3.1.

Proof of Theorem 2.3.1. Let (M^{n+1}, g) be a closed Riemannian manifold with $2 \leq n \leq 6$. The nested sweepout framework constructed in Sections 1.3–1.5 provides a continuous family of hypersurfaces sweeping out M. Applying the non-excessive tightening procedure of Chodosh–Liokumovich–Spolaor to this nested sweepout yields a non-excessive sweepout $\Phi \in \mathcal{S}_{\mathrm{nm}}$.

By Theorem 2.2.5, there exists a stationary varifold V with $\mathbf{M}(V) \leq \mathcal{F}(\Phi)$.

Assume there is no mass cancellation (i.e., $\Theta^n(V, x) = 1$ for $\mathbf{M}(V)$-almost every $x \in \mathbf{spt}(V)$). By Theorem 2.4.1, V is integral and rectifiable.

By Theorem 2.5.4, V satisfies the α-structural hypothesis.

The non-excessive condition ensures that V is stable. Therefore, all hypotheses of Wickramasekera's regularity theorem (Theorem 2.5.1) are satisfied. We conclude that $\mathbf{sing} V = \emptyset$, i.e., $\mathbf{spt}(V)$ is a smooth embedded minimal hypersurface. $\square$

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